

THE SHORT LEDGER

Fourth Wall Gaming

PRELUDE

Purewater is built on water and is entirely unembarrassed about it.

There is no ground. There are buildings, and there is water, and between them there are ledges a yard wide with no rail and a drop into a channel that has been carrying the city's traffic, its cargo, its gossip and its dead since before anybody kept a record. Houses come straight up out of it. Doors open onto steps that go down under the surface and keep going. Everything that matters travels by flat-bottomed boat, poled and rowed and shouted at, and every single journey costs a fare.

Anybody raised there can handle a boat. It is like walking, and nobody remarks on it, and no child has ever been praised for it.

The other half of that — the half nobody in Purewater ever bothers to say out loud, because saying it would be like announcing that water is wet — is that nobody *else* can. A stranger in that city cannot move a sack of flour across it, cannot get to the temple, cannot send a message, cannot flee, without hiring somebody who was born there.

There are no horses either. The land stops at Caravan Square and does not resume. A column coming down the Anminster road arrives at the gate and then has to be taken to pieces and put into boats in public, slowly, in front of everybody, one crate at a time, which is the most exposed a great house ever gets and the reason great houses hate the place.

Once there were Dragon Kings. They are gone and every child knows it. What is left of them is old armour on border lords, a name on a barony, and a small number of men who would like the old power back badly enough to pay whatever it costs and to let somebody else pay most of it.

The Lake Lady's Tourney comes round once a year — archery, single combat, and a scramble across the canals — and it is older than the Governor's office, and for the week of it the city fills up and the law goes quiet and everybody makes a year's money in six days.

This year Baron Hanzo di Teufel came down the road for it, with Dragon Knights at his back and a champion nobody had been permitted to see.

None of that is what this book is about.

This book is about a half-orc who collected debts on the Shoals bridges, and who found three accounts short in one week for the same reason, and who — because nobody had ever asked her opinion about anything in her entire life, and she had one — went and had a look.

CHAPTER 1 — THE SHORT LEDGER



KAG HAD MADE THE SHOALS ROUND EVERY WEEK FOR FOUR YEARS, eleven calls between the ice-house and the smugglers' jetties, and she could have done the whole of it asleep and on two occasions very nearly had — and the thing nobody ever understood about that round, including the man who paid her for it, was that it was not frightening anybody. It was a conversation with eleven people about money, conducted at dawn, in the cold, with a book.

Nobody on that peninsula was afraid of her. That is what four years buys. They saw eight feet of her coming up the jetty and they got the box out from under the counter and then they talked about the weather.

Marn at the ice-house had it counted out before she was through the door and asked after her knee. The two Tolliver brothers tried the same joke they had been trying since spring and laughed at it themselves. The woman who smoked eels gave her a fish, as she did every single week and had never once been asked to, and it went in her coat and it would be breakfast.

Eight of them were ordinary.

Three of them were short.

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Not light. Not fiddled. *Short* — with the money not there and said to her face, which nobody ever does, because the entire point of the arrangement is that nobody should have to.

Deller at the net-loft, who had never been a copper out in nine years, had a quarter of it and put both hands flat on the bench when he said so.

The tally-clerk on the middle jetty had none at all and did not look away.

And old Sabbe, who sold ice off the third stair and was eighty if she was a day, said it perfectly cheerfully, the way you'd mention rain.

All three of them on or under the Fishmarket bridge.

And all three of them, once they had said it, said something else — not as an excuse, more as a thing they would genuinely have liked her opinion on, and Deller put it shortest.

“Two of them stood on that bridge Tuesday and took a barrel off my boy. Off him, out of his hands, on the bridge, at eleven in the morning.”

He was not angry. That was the strange part.

“Nobody made them pay for that, Kag. So what am I paying for?”

There is no good answer to that question and Kag had four years of watching a man not give one.

“Let's make it up next time, yeah?”

Deller let out a breath he had been holding since he saw her coming up the jetty, and said *yeah, yeah, all right*, and watched her get the book out, and watched her write — and something in his shoulders came down. Not because the debt had gone anywhere, because it hadn't. Because it was *written*, and a thing written in Kag's book was a thing that was going to be dealt with properly by somebody who could count.

Deller, net-loft. 3/4 short. Carried. Barrel taken off the boy on the Fishmarket bridge, Tues, abt 11. Asking what he pays for.

Same entry for the tally-clerk. Same for Sabbe, and Sabbe watched her write it with her chin up and said, “You put it down right, girl,” which from Sabbe was a declaration of love.

Three entries. Same bridge. Same week.

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The Fishmarket bridge is a hump of stone over the cut, wide enough for four abreast, and at that hour it should have been solid with handcarts going to the market on the far side.

It was not, because there were two men standing on the crown of it.

Dragon-blazoned harness, good kit, cloaks against the damp. Not doing anything. One of them had his back to the traffic and was eating something.

And the whole morning’s trade was going round them in single file, hard against the parapet — carts tipped up on one wheel, fish carried at shoulder height, a boy with a tray of ice turning sideways and shuffling — and nobody was saying one word about it.

She could hear them from the bottom of the steps, which the people squeezing past probably could not. One of them was telling the other a long story about a woman in Anminster, and he was not lowering his voice, because it had not occurred to him that there was any reason on earth to.

Kag went up the bridge, friendly like.

“Ullo then lads. How are you on this fine morning?”

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The storyteller stopped mid-sentence, and not because of anything she had done. Eight feet of half-orc had come up a bridge at him out of a fish market at dawn, and he had had a week of carters looking at their boots, and this was the most interesting thing that had happened since Anminster.

“*Morning*,” he said, and he said it delightedly, and he meant it. About thirty, unshaven, with the easy manner of a man who had been a soldier a long time and was no longer very impressed by anything. “God’s teeth. What do they feed you?”

He was grinning. It was not a sneer. It was a man enjoying himself.

The other one was younger, and had not said anything, and had his hand on his belt near the hilt, and it had gone there fast and had not come away again.

“You’re not the fella that carries the ice,” the storyteller said. “Is there a *tribe* of you?” A beat, and then, entirely without malice, in exactly the tone you’d use about the weather: “Here — you understand me all right, do you?”

“They feed me fish.”

She had one in her coat, as it happened.

“Listen — I’ve work to do on the other side of this bridge and this is taking a little too long. So if you don’t mind I’ll hop on through and then I’ll be back in a little while.” She let that sit. “Just thought I’d, y’know, ask nicely.”

And the storyteller laughed — a real one, out of the belly — and stepped sideways without any ceremony at all.

“Go on then, fish.” Still grinning. “Nicely asked.”

The younger one moved slower and did not stop watching her hands, and she went through the gap between them, which was a gap because one of them had made it properly and the other had made it grudgingly.

And here is what she could not help noticing on the way past, because it was happening on both sides of her at once.

Six carts had been waiting. Not one of them had been let through. The old man at the front of that queue had been standing there since before she arrived and was standing there still.

She had asked.

Nobody had told him no. Nobody had told him anything at all.

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Halfway across, the storyteller called after her, conversationally, because he was bored and she had been the entertainment and it was not yet eight in the morning.

“Here — you want to get your business done early, big lass. It’s going to be a circus after noon.”

She turned. It cost nothing and he was plainly delighted.

“The Baron’s in today. Whole column, off the landward road. There’s twenty-five of us coming over that water before dark and we’re all going to want feeding.”

“The Baron? Which one?”

“Di Teufel.” He said it as though she ought to have heard of it and was enjoying that she hadn’t. “Baron Hanzo di Teufel, out of the east. We’re his.” And then, really pleased with himself now, leaning in about six inches — which put him closer to her than any of the carters had got all morning — “Here for the Tourney, same as everybody. Except we’ve got a *man* for the sand. Single combat, day after the archery.”

He tapped the side of his nose. He actually did it.

“You want to keep your money in your pocket on that one, big lass. Or put it all on the same place I have.”

“**Tarrent.**”

That was the younger one. The first word he had said. It was not loud and it was not friendly, and the storyteller — Tarrent, then — stopped with his mouth open for about half a second.

Then it was gone and he was easy again. “Ah, he’s all right. Nothing anybody in this town doesn’t know by Thursday.”

But he had straightened up, and stopped leaning, and his hands had found his belt.

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Kag smiled at the younger one.

The smile is a real weapon and she had never had to practise it. She had the jaw for it and the teeth for it, and forty years of people flinching at her face by accident meant she knew exactly how much of it to use, and the younger one got about a third.

He did not step back. He went very slightly grey around the mouth and did not step back, which for a man his age in front of a colleague was about as well as it could have gone.

“No. It’s all right, friend.” Pleasant. Reasonable. The voice she used on a man who was four weeks behind. “So you’re just holding up the traffic till your lord passes. And requisitioning supplies for your men, more generally.” A beat. “Like I said — only asking in a friendly manner. I might be able to help with supply issues. Who’d be a good person to talk to, in your organisation? A quartermaster, or something.”

And Tarrent laughed.

Not unkindly. It was the same laugh as before — except it went on a little too long, and it changed shape while it was happening, and by the end of it he was looking at her with something uncomfortably close to pity.

“*Buy it?*”

He said it the way you would say it to a child who had offered to pay for the weather.

“Love. There’s twenty-five of us coming over that water tonight and about four hundred camped out east, and we’ve been on the road nine weeks.” He gestured vaguely at the fish market, the jetties, the whole peninsula, the way a man indicates a view. “What do you think we’ve been *eating?*”

The younger one had not blinked.

“You want to talk to a quartermaster.” Tarrent was still amused. “Sweetheart, if we had a quartermaster I’d have had a hot dinner in Anminster.”

And there it was, and neither of them thought he had said anything remarkable.

There was no supply chain to sell to. No office, no requisition, no name to ask for, because none of that had been necessary for nine weeks. They walked over a bridge and things came off carts and not one living soul had ever presented them with a bill.

She had just offered to sell fish to men who had stopped understanding why anybody would buy it.

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The younger one spoke for the second time.

“What’s your name?”

Not aggressive. Flat, straight at her, and his hand had come off his belt to ask it, which was somehow worse.

“I’m Kag.”

She was already turning.

“Ask around. If you fellas ever bother to actually talk to the people you’re stealing from, you’ll find out who I am quick as you like.”

A beat.

“Nice to meet you all.”

And she walked off down the other side, and behind her *stealing* landed a great deal harder than the smile had — because Tarrent had been calling it nine weeks on the road, and provisioning, and *what do you think we’ve been eating*, and not one of those is the word she had used, and she had used it pleasantly, and she was already gone.

Behind them the queue still had not moved.

Three carts had turned round and given up entirely, and the old man at the front was standing exactly where he had been standing when she arrived.

CHAPTER 2 — WHAT DO YOU THINK WE’VE BEEN EATING



CROWBILL HAD BEEN USING THE FLAT LEAD ROOF OVER THE COOKSHOP OVENS FOR THIRTY YEARS, which meant that in October it was the warmest place in Purewater and smelled of mutton fat and woodsmoke, and that every single person who worked for him had at some point in their life climbed that stair with their heart going and been told to sit down by a man eating out of a paper who did not look up.

He did not look up.

There were two men at the far end by the stair-head who were exactly what everybody pictures when they picture Crowbill’s — thick, quiet, and entirely unnecessary at that height, which was the point of them.

“Deller and Sabbe,” he said. “Who’s the third?”

And Kag, who had been up the stair for perhaps four seconds and had a whole opening prepared, threw the opening in the canal for the second time that day.

“Tally-clerk on the middle jetty.”

“Mm.” He ate. “Go on, then.”

So she gave him all of it. The pattern. The bridge. The word *asking* rather than *short* — because that was the whole of it and it had taken her the length of a jetty to understand why it mattered. Two men standing on the crown of a bridge doing nothing whatsoever while six carts went single file round them and nobody said a word. No quartermaster. No requisition. Nine weeks and not one bill presented to anybody for anything.

Twenty-five more of them coming over the water before dark. Four hundred east.

And the column in today.

Crowbill ate his dinner out of the paper and listened to the whole thing without one interruption, which she had not expected and which was considerably harder to talk into than an argument would have been.

At the end of it he folded the paper over.

"Cost it," he said. "The whole city, not your bridges. By Friday."

"You've got two men who do that."

"I've got two men who *count*." He wiped his hands. "That is not the same thing and you have known it wasn't since you were about fifteen, and it is why I am asking you and not them."

She went down the stair with her ears hot, and he did not say goodnight, because he never did.

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Her place was a room over a chandler's on the Lullwater, up an outside stair, one window on the water and a door that opened outward — because a door that opens inward is a door you can be pushed through, and she had known that since she was nineteen and had never once lived behind another kind.

There was a bed she'd had made specially, because nothing in this city is made for a woman of that size and she had got tired of asking.

A stove. And one whole wall of shelf with five years of ledgers on it in order.

It took four hours. She did it properly, with the eel-woman's fish eaten cold at the table and the window open to the smell of tar, and it was the happiest she had been all year, which she would not have admitted to a living soul.

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The costing was the easy half and it was very much worse than she had expected.

Eleven bridges she could name where they had been standing. Per bridge, per day, you could price the traffic that was not crossing, the trade going the long way round, and the cut that therefore did not come. The barrel off Deller's boy was trivially small. The *queue behind it* was not. Six carts turned round on one bridge in one hour, and she had watched three of them do it while a soldier told her about a woman in Anminster.

Then the second-order line, which was the one that mattered and which she wrote on a fresh leaf because it deserved the room.

Three shortfalls this week becomes eleven next week and thirty the week after — not because anybody is dishonest, but because the question Deller asked is a *good question*, and questions travel a great deal faster than fish.

She drew it as a curve. Then she sat and looked at the curve for a while with the window open and the tar coming in off the water, and did not enjoy it.

And the Pearl on top of it, because she had been asked for the whole city and the Pearl is a quarter of everything. If the Pearl ever shut, the eleven bridges would stop mattering by the same afternoon.

She underlined that once, on the left-hand page, and did not think about it again for two days, and when she did think about it again it would be while standing in a room with eleven houses dark outside the window.

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The second half of the evening she spent on a question nobody had asked her, because she had put it in herself and because it was the sort of thing you put in when a man has called you *sweetheart* on a bridge in front of six carts.

How dangerous are they, actually? Not as a column. As individuals, on this water, at night. What happens if one of them goes in the river. What happens if two of them do, quietly, and it is never spoken of.

She took her time over it and she was honest, which is a harder discipline with a page than with a person.

And on the left-hand page, underlined once, in her own hand, she wrote down what a body at the Guild landing costs and who it gets charged to, and the figure had four thousand people in it, and she would be very glad of that page before the week was out.

CHAPTER 3 — FOUR SHEETS AND A CURVE



HESSA HAD KEPT THE TALLIES FOR THE WHOLE OF THAT WATER OUT OF A BACK ROOM BEHIND A CHANDLERY since she was nineteen years old, which was long enough to have formed one settled opinion about the trade, and the opinion was this: almost nobody who works for a man like Crowbill ever brings him anything. They bring him *problems*, which they have decorated, in the hope of being thanked for the decoration.

She had never once lost anything and had never once read anything she was not meant to, and between those two facts she had built a life nobody in that city could see the edges of.

The half-orc came in at six with four loose sheets.

Not the book. Nobody ever got the book, and Hessa respected that more than she would have respected being handed it.

She went through them standing up, fast, the way she did.

Eleven bridges. Priced by the day, by the bridge, with the traffic that was not crossing costed separately from the cut that was not coming, which was a distinction Hessa had been trying to get two grown men to understand since Candlemas. Then the second-order line. Then a curve, drawn by hand, with three shortfalls at one end of it and thirty at the other.

And the Pearl, on its own, at the bottom.

“That’s a curve,” Hessa said.

“It is.”

“He’ll like that.” She squared the sheets on the table. “He won’t like where it goes.”

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The rest of the evening was the part that went wrong, and it went wrong in the most interesting possible way, which is that it produced nothing.

Kag had spent the afternoon asking about the men on the bridges — who they were, where they drank, what their names were — and had come back with a face like a closed account.

“Nobody knows anything.”

“Nobody knows anything,” Hessa agreed, because she had been getting the same all week and had not until that moment realised it was a fact rather than an absence.

Nine weeks, and not one name. You got *dragonshits*. You got “the tall one” and “the one with the beard” from four separate people who each plainly meant a different man. The publican at the Oyster said they had been in twice; the potboy said every night; both of them were entirely certain. One of Marn’s lads swore blind there had been four on the Fishmarket bridge on Tuesday, and there had been two, because Kag had counted them herself that morning.

It was not that people would not tell you. It was that they had nothing to tell.

Everybody on that water had spent nine weeks *not looking at them* — going round, eyes down, getting past — and you cannot remember a face you have spent two months deliberately not seeing.

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“I think we have to do a little more than that,” Kag said.

Hessa did not say no.

What she did was sit down, finally, which she had not done all evening, and which was very much worse — because Hessa standing up is Hessa on an errand and Hessa sitting down is Hessa having a conversation.

“I think we have to put one or two of these boats under the water for a while.” Kag had both hands flat on the table. “It’s a protection racket. If we’re not protecting anyone—”

A beat.

“One of them called me *sweetheart*.”

“Boats.” Hessa thought about it properly, and you could see her doing the sums, because she did them the same way Kag did. “Two of theirs on the water at the Guild landing, and whatever came off the barge today. It’d cost them a week and there’s no body in it.”

A pause.

“It’s not against the code. It’s not even clever enough to be against the code.”

She turned the cup a quarter-turn on the table.

“And he’d want to have said yes first. You know that.”

Then she looked up, and she had a face like a closed ledger and had had it since she was nineteen, and it did not change at all when she said:

“One of them called you *sweetheart*.”

She let that be the whole thing for a moment.

“Kag. You brought me four sheets and a curve this afternoon and it’s the best bit of work anybody’s done for him in a year, and Hessa saying that means something.” No emphasis anywhere. “And you’ve just given me eleven bridges, a protection racket that doesn’t protect, and *one of them called me sweetheart*, all in the same breath, and I can’t tell which one you’re actually here about.”

She picked up the cup and drank what was left of it herself.

“So I’ll ask it the way he’d ask it. If the sweetheart one had said nothing to you all morning — would the boats still be a good idea?”

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“We both know it’s a good idea, even without the insult,” Kag said. “You know me. I’m all about business and what works. The only blowback I can see is if these accidents get attributed to us in particular, and if we do it right there shouldn’t be a problem.”

And then, leaning back:

“And with these fuckers it doesn’t matter if we’re loud on the streets. Because they’re not paying attention to any of it anyway.”

Hessa took that. She ran it through and it held and she did not pretend otherwise, which is the entire reason people told her things.

“Yeah. All right. It’s a good idea.”

She set the cup down.

“And you’re right about the last bit, and I’ll go further. They don’t know who anybody is. Nine weeks and they’ve not learned a name either — it runs both ways. You could sink both of those boats on Thursday and they’d spend a fortnight looking at the Dredgers, because the Dredgers are who you look at when something goes under and they’ve been shouting for a month.”

That was not comfort. She said it flatly, as a fact about the world, and they both heard the other half of it at the same moment and neither of them said it.

“Here’s the only thing I’ll stand on.”

She held up one finger, which from Hessa was practically shouting.

“He said *cost it*. He didn’t say *do* anything. You go under the water without him, and if it goes right he’ll say nothing — and if it goes wrong you’ll have done it on your own name and not his.” A beat. “And he’ll still say nothing. That’s the bit people miss about him.”

She pushed her chair back.

“So ask him. He’s on the Lullwater tonight and I can put you in front of him before midnight. Take the boats to him the way you took me the curve. *Cost* it, don’t sell it, and he’ll either say yes or he’ll tell you what you’ve got wrong, and either way you’ll be better off than guessing.”

She stood.

“And Kag. The four sheets were good. He’s not going to say so.”

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The Oyster was filling up by then, and over in the corner a boatman called Sim who ran the Guild landing ferry had been talking for twenty minutes and had no intention of stopping.

“They can’t come in, see.” He was enjoying himself enormously. “No road. So the whole lot of them stop dead at the Square and everything’s got to go on the water, and we all went down to watch, because what else are you doing at noon.”

Then he got to the part he had been building to and dropped his voice, which made the eight people round him lean in, which he knew.

“The Baron comes over first. Stands up in the bow, no hand on anything, bare head — lets the whole city have a look at him. Bold as you like.”

A beat.

“And then they bring the *box*.”

Somebody said something about gold and Sim waved it away, irritably, like a man being interrupted in church.

“Four to carry it and two to keep us off, and it’s a bad set of steps and it went over about *that* far—” he showed with his hands, a good fifteen degrees “—and one of them called the other one something you’d not say in front of your mother.”

“And?”

“And *nothing*.” Sim was delighted. “Not a sound out of it. Not a knock, not a word, nothing shifting inside. And them curtains are laced. Not tied — *laced*. Bottom and sides, like a boot.”

The potboy said his cousin was on the caravan road and said it had been like that the whole way. Nine weeks. Never opened.

An old man said it would be relics, for the Prince. A woman said it would be a wife.

And the enormous half-orc at the back of the crowd said, cheerfully, to the room:

“Could be a monster! Something green with big teeth!”

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It got a laugh. A proper one — the whole corner of the room, and the potboy had to put a jug down, and Sim laughed hardest of anybody because his story had been running twenty minutes and he had been losing them.

“*Big teeth!*” he said, and hit the table.

The woman who had thought it was a wife said, “Green, though, Kag — that’s the detail,” and somebody else said “that’s why they’re facing in, they’re keeping it *fed*,” and for about thirty seconds the Moist Oyster was a very good place to be.

Somebody bought her a drink. Hessa, watching from the end of the bar, made a private note that it was the first time she had seen that happen in nine years.

And then Sim — warmed right up, and talking to Kag now rather than the room, because she was the one who had made his story land:

“You’d not get near it anyway. They’ve put the lot on the far side of High Isle, the seaward pier. The Baron’s own ship — the one that *steams*.” He pulled a face. “Have you seen that? Where the hull meets the water. Steams like a kettle, all day, cold or not. I don’t go past it any more. The ferrymen won’t take a fare that way.”

He drank.

“Only twenty aboard and no more. Everything else is east at the Vantt place — horses, farriers, the whole circus. So there’s nothing on this water of theirs but the two lighters they’re running stores out on, and those tie up at the Guild landing overnight, because there’s no room at the pier.”

He said it exactly the way a man says a thing that could not possibly be of interest to anybody.

“Two lads on them. Not even proper watchmen. Sleep aboard because it’s warmer than a tent.”

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Hessa did not say anything until they were forty yards along the fondamenta with the Oyster’s noise shut behind them and nothing but black water on the left.

“Two lads sleep aboard.”

Just that. The way she would read out a figure.

She walked another ten yards.

“You said boats. You’ve been saying boats all evening and I’ve been agreeing with you about boats — and boats has got a body in it now, and it got one about four minutes ago while a room full of people were laughing at a joke about teeth.”

Her breath went up in the cold. It had turned properly cold since dark.

“I’m not telling you no. I’ve said my one thing and I’m not going to be the woman who says it twice.” A pause. “But you’ve written a lot down today and you’ve got a head for it. So take four minutes and write this one down as well, before you’re standing in front of him.”

And here is the question Hessa asked, on a dark fondamenta, forty yards from a room still laughing about a monster with big teeth — the question that is the entire reason four thousand people in the low canals went on living their ordinary lives that week without ever knowing how close it came.

“If a lighter goes under at the Guild landing at three in the morning with two boys asleep in it — what’s the bill, and who gets handed it?”

She already knew the answer, because she had read the four sheets.

So did Kag. She had written it on a left-hand page at one o’clock that afternoon and underlined it once.

CHAPTER 4 — WHO ON THAT COLUMN HAS EVER POLED A LIGHTER



KAG WENT UP THE STAIR TO THE LEAD ROOF A LITTLE BEFORE MIDNIGHT with a proposal about boats, and came down about forty minutes later having been taken apart, reassembled, and handed a city — and the remarkable thing about the whole encounter, which she would turn over for years, was that the man barely said forty words and she did nearly all of the work herself, which was of course the point and had been the point every time he had ever done it to anybody.

There was a lamp and a pot of something. He did not look up when she came off the stair.

She did not sell it. She costed it, the way Hessa had told her to, and she was afterwards quite certain that Hessa had known exactly what would happen if she did.

One. Eleven bridges, the curve, the Pearl on top. He had read the four sheets. He did not mention them, then or ever.

Two. There was nothing to sell them. No quartermaster, no requisition, nine weeks of nobody presenting a bill. She had tried it that morning on a bridge and been laughed at by a man who then called her *sweetheart*, and she said so out loud, because he would find out

anyway and because being wrong in your own words is very much cheaper than being caught in somebody else's.

Three — and here she slowed down, because this was the piece she had got to at about four o'clock that afternoon with the window open and the tar coming in.

They could not come into this city. Nobody can. There is no road past Caravan Square and there never has been, which is the only reason Purewater has ever been worth anything to anybody. Four hundred of them were east at the Vantt place with the horses. Twenty were on a ship at the seaward pier. And for nine weeks they had been a column that *moved* — and as of noon that day, they had stopped.

A static four hundred eat. Every loaf, every barrel, every bolt of canvas, every nail. And every message between that estate and that ship has to cross water.

"They don't have to pay us," Kag said. "They have to *come through* us."

A beat.

"Those are different problems and we've been solving the wrong one."

Then the lighters — *not sunk*, and she said that part plainly and first, because a body at the Guild landing gets answered at the Fishmarket and she had put a figure on that at one o'clock in the afternoon and the figure had four thousand people in it.

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"Are they local or out-of-townners?" she asked. "The lads on the lighters."

"I don't know," Crowbill said.

He said it without a trace of embarrassment, which from a man who knew things for a living was worth noticing and which she did notice.

“Started this morning. Nothing on this water is a day old to me.” He turned the cup a half-turn on the lead. “It’s the right question and it’s the first one. Everything else is downstream of it.”

Then he sat back against the chimney-stack and let her get there herself, because that is how he had taught everybody who had ever worked for him anything at all.

“Nine weeks on the road,” he said. “Four abreast. Horses, farriers, armourers. They came four hundred miles overland out of the east.”

A gull went over. He watched it.

“Ask yourself who on that column has ever poled a lighter.”

*
**

And there it was.

It had been sitting in front of her since Sim said it in the Oyster and she had walked straight past it, because she had been thinking about hulls.

Not one of them can crew a boat. Cavalry out of a country with roads, in a city that has none, and the two things they need moved between a ship at the seaward pier and four hundred men east of the isles are food and messages, and both of those go on water, and there is not a man in that entire company who can do it.

So they hired.

They hired in a city where every boatman on every stair either pays Crowbill or knows somebody who does. They hired in a hurry, that morning. And the two lads sleeping on those lighters because it was warmer than a tent were almost certainly *from here*.

“Yep.” Kag heard herself say it before she had decided to. “Boss. You’re a fucking genius.”

“Mm,” said Crowbill, in the tone of a man being told it was raining.

*
**

“Who’s running the whisper network? If I go round asking it won’t be subtle.”

“There isn’t a network.” No modesty in it whatsoever. “There’s boys and there’s ferrymen and there’s me. Everything that happens on this water gets seen by somebody who is either eleven years old or holding a pole, and both of them will talk to me for a copper, and neither of them knows they’re doing anything.”

He nodded down at the stair-head, where a boy was sitting.

“That’s Pell. He ran for you this morning. There’s about forty of him.”

Then he held up a finger, which for Crowbill was a lecture.

“**Hessa**, for the boys. She pays them, she knows which ones can count and which ones make things up, and she’ll have four of them on the Guild landing by first light asking nothing and watching everything. Names, faces, whether they go home at the end of a shift and which stair they go home *to*.”

Second finger.

“**Kerrin**. Brown coat, dockside, entirely forgettable. He’ll sit in the Oyster and the Siren’s Call for two days and come back with who those boys’ mothers are. He follows and he does not close, ever, and if he’s made he buys them a drink and comes home, and I have never had to explain that to him twice.”

His hand dropped.

“Use them both. Tell Hessa I said so and she’ll believe you, because she’ll have already worked out why.”

*
**

“I find it hard not to be loud, boss,” Kag said. “I wanted to get a sense of the land before I brought anything to you. But yeah. I’ll work on that.”

And he looked at her for a moment with what was, on him, something close to fondness — the way a man looks at a heron that has just done something herons do.

"You can't be quiet."

He said it as a simple fact about the world, like the tide.

"You're eight foot of you and everybody on this water knows your face. Trying to be quiet is a waste of a good afternoon."

He drained the cup.

"So be loud where it's *useful*. You standing on a bridge saying the word out loud in front of forty people — that's not a mistake. That's a thing I can't buy. Half the Shoals has told that story today and every one of them stood a bit straighter telling it."

He got up and brushed the lead dust off his coat.

"What I want is you choosing *when*. That's all. Loud on purpose is a tool."

A beat.

"Loud because a man called you sweetheart is a man knowing where to find you."

And he went down the stair without saying goodnight, because he never did.

*
**

Hessa took about ninety seconds and one sentence of explanation, and by the time Kag had finished she was already working out which four boys and had opinions about two of them.

"Not Pell." She was writing while she said it. "Pell's yours now, and they'll have seen him run to you."

Pell's yours now, said while writing something else, in a back room behind a chandlery, at midnight.

That was the whole ceremony. Crowbill had nodded at a stair-head and Hessa had said four words without looking up, and nobody had made anything of it, and Kag went down the fundamenta afterwards in the cold trying to work out why her chest felt strange.

It meant she paid him. It meant she did not lend him out. It meant that if he got picked up it was her problem and nobody else's.

He was eleven, or said he was. He could count to a hundred and could not read. He slept in the gap over the cookshop ovens on the Lullwater along with two other boys and, in winter, sometimes four, and Crowbill had never once mentioned that he allowed it, because everybody understood that mentioning it would end it. He had taken to standing about four feet behind her left shoulder when she was stopped, which he had copied off somebody, and which she had not told him to stop doing.

It was the first thing she had ever been given that breathed.

"I'll put Jeb and the Coyle girl on the landing from first light," Hessa said, still writing, "and they'll be selling cockles. Because they will actually be selling cockles."

CHAPTER 5 — WHO MENDED HER



PELL CAME UP THE OUTSIDE STAIR THREE AT A TIME AT SEVEN IN THE MORNING and had plainly been running a while, and the reason he had been running a while — the reason he had a stitch and could not get the words out and had to put his hands on his knees on her landing — was that the Lullwater from the north stairs is a mile of fundamenta and bridges, and he had no boat fare on him, because Kag had not thought to give him one.

She noticed that. She noticed it properly, the way you notice a thing you are going to fix.

“Kag — Kag—”

“Breathe.”

“Hessa says come. She says now and she says the *Pearl*.” Another breath. “There’s a girl cut. Last night. One of the houses.”

*
**

Here is what Kag did not do, and it is the single reason any of the rest of this happened.

She did not go.

She stood on her own landing at seven in the morning with the whole city already running toward the Pearl, and she stopped, and

thought for a moment, and said the thing out loud that had been bothering her since *cut*.

“Who’d want to carve up a girl from the Pearl? Makes no sense.”

Then:

“Pell. Go and find out how she’s not dead. What saved her.”

He did not ask why. That was the thing about him — eleven years old and he had never once asked her why, and one day she was going to have to teach him to, and she knew it, and she had not started.

“How’s she not dead,” he repeated, getting it right. “Who fixed her.”

“That’s it. Not who cut her. **Who mended her.** And how long it took.”

He was off before she had finished, and she shouted after him and he stopped on the second step.

She gave him a fare. Two, in fact — one out and one back, which nobody had given him the day before and which was precisely why he had arrived with a stitch.

“Boats, Pell. Not legs.”

He looked at the coppers in his hand for a second longer than a boy looks at money, and then he was gone.

*
**

She went the long way to Hessa because Crowbill had told her to stay off the Fishmarket bridge and the Oyster and the Guild landing, and she discovered that going the long way in that city takes forty minutes and three fares and that she was going to be doing it for two days.

By the time she got there it was full light and the water was talking.

Hessa had the back room open and there were already two boys in it eating, and one of them was Jeb, who should have been on the Guild landing selling cockles.

“Before you start,” Hessa said, “he’s here because the landing’s shut.”

She turned a page.

“They’ve put men on it. Not Marisette’s — the *Baron*’s. Six of them, off the barge, since about four this morning, and nobody’s getting near it.”

*
**

She did not stop working while she told the rest of it. She never did.

“Sylph’s Embrace. One of Constantine’s girls — Emmeralda, the elf, the one everyone goes to see.” She squared a stack. “Cut from here to here. One line, all down the front. Sometime after three.”

A beat.

“She’s alive. Nobody can tell me how, and everybody’s got a story about it.”

“Marisette shut the whole island before it was light and she’s had people on the quay since. And she’s taken a fella.”

She stopped, briefly, which from Hessa was a held breath.

“They’re saying it was Randall.”

She let that sit, because she knew Kag would want a second with it.

“Pearl boy. Raised at the Promise of Heaven, ran errands on that quay since he was smaller than Jeb, everybody knows his face. And three separate women out of two houses will swear he was in last week, drinking, and one of them says she called out to him and he laughed at her.”

She finally looked up.

“So that’s what the water’s saying. And it’s saying it *sadly*, which is worse. Nobody’s angry. They’re all saying *that poor boy, what happened to him*.”

*
**

And Kag did the sums on the way it had been told, because that is what she did with everything, including grief.

A house on the Pearl goes over at three in the morning. Marisette locks the island down and has a man in a bag before first light.

And at four o'clock, on the other side of the city — a different island, a different water, nothing whatever to do with any of it — six of the Baron's men walk two local boys off the Guild landing and put them in a boat going east.

Same hour.

Nobody in that room had put those two things next to each other. Nobody in the city had, because the city had spent the morning on the Pearl, where the story was, and the story was a beautiful boy with a lovely face who everybody was sad about.

"Why the sudden switch in the Baron's boating arrangements?" Kag said.

Hessa put the pen down, which she had not done all morning.

"I can't tell you it's connected. I can tell you I don't like it either, and I'd want to know why a man who's been letting local lads sleep on his boats for a day decides at four in the morning that he'd rather do it himself."

She thought about it.

"Could be nothing. Could be somebody counted something and didn't like the answer. Could be they always meant to swap the crews and it landed on the same night by luck." A shrug. "Things do. That's the trap in this work and you know it better than most."

Then the practical half, because there was always a practical half.

"East is Vantt land. Four hundred of them, the horses, the whole tail of it, and it is *not in the city* — no canals, no roofs, no forty people who know your face. You'd be walking across open ground at a camp." She looked at Kag steadily. "You. Across open ground."

"But," she said, and picked the pen back up, "you've got a reason to be there that stands up, which is more than anybody else in Purewater has got. Two men who took Crowbill's water and the Baron's coin in

the same week have been carried off east, and somebody has got to find out whether they're working or whether they're in a hole."

She tore a strip off the page and held it out.

"That's collections. That's literally your job, and he told you to do it."

CHAPTER 6 — TWENTY-FIVE TENTS



KAG STEPPED OFF A BOAT ONTO GROUND FOR THE FIRST TIME IN ELEVEN YEARS and very nearly fell over, because the world had stopped moving up and down and nobody had warned her that it would.

Grass. Mud. A hedge.

And the smell, which was the second shock and somehow larger than the first: horse, and woodsmoke, and latrine, and cut grass, and not one single note of tar or fish or lye anywhere in it. She stood at the top of the Vantt landing with her boots in actual earth and had the strangest four seconds of the decade.

It had taken until noon and four fares, the long way round, east across the Mouth with the sea on the right.

*
**

Rew's chandlery was a long shed at the landing, and Rew was sixty and had a bad hip and one look at the size of her told him exactly whose rope he had been buying for nine years.

He gave her an hour, as advertised, and he gave it to her by talking while he worked, so that anybody looking up from the meadow saw a Chandler and a large customer discussing cordage, which they were, for most of it.

And the meadow was below the house, laid out in rows, in full view of the shed door.

So she counted, because that was why she had come.

Twenty-five tents. Forty-one horses. One farrier.

She counted it three times and it did not change.

*
**

Four hundred, Tarrent had said, cheerfully, with his hand on his belt, on a bridge, in front of six carts and an old man. *About four hundred camped out east.*

There was a servants' tail and a cook-line and a string of remounts, and generously — very generously — you might get to a hundred and fifty souls on that meadow, of whom perhaps ninety could hold a sword.

Not four hundred. Not a third of it.

And the entire city of Purewater — forty thousand people, eleven bridges gone quiet, a rope-seller who had stopped asking for credit, an eighty-year-old woman short on her ice for the first time in her life — had spent nine weeks being occupied by a number that nobody had ever counted, because there is no road east and nobody goes, and four hundred is not a fact, it is a rumour in harness.

She wanted to be closer. She wanted the inside of the rows and she wanted to know which of those tents were cold.

"Can I pass for a labour hand?" she said. "Somebody who's supposed to be there?"

*
**

Rew looked at her for a while, and then at the meadow, and then did the sum she had been hoping he would do.

"They're taking hands on," he said. "Have been since yesterday. Local men, by the day, cash at dusk. Mucking out, water, wood,

moving feed. There's eleven or twelve down there already and half of them came off my landing this morning."

He scratched his jaw.

"Nobody's checking anything. There's no clerk and no list. A big lad turns up at the horse-lines with his sleeves up and starts shifting something heavy, and the only question anybody asks is *whose barrow is that*."

He went back to the rope.

"Which is not to say I'd advise it."

*
**

Here is the thing, and it had taken forty years to be worth anything.

She would not have to act.

She had spent her entire life being looked at exactly once by people deciding what she was, and every single one of them had got it wrong in precisely the same direction — muscle, hire, thing-that-lifts — and it had cost her a trade, a name, and every door in Purewater that opens on charm. Forty years of it. She had never once been able to use it for anything.

There was a water butt by the shed that took two men.

She put it on one shoulder, got a hand on the rim, and walked down the slope into the meadow at the exact speed of a woman who has been told to put something somewhere and would rather not have been.

And the camp let her in the way a gate doesn't.

A man at the cook-line looked up, saw a barrel and an arm holding it, and went back to his bowl. Somebody else said "over by the lines" without checking whether she had been asking. A boy with an armful of tack changed direction so as not to get in her way and did not look at her face, because nobody looks at the face of a thing that is carrying something heavy.

Nobody had ever made it that easy. Nobody had ever made *anything* that easy.

She walked into an enemy camp in daylight with a barrel on her shoulder, and the only thing that got her in was the thing she had hated for forty years.

*
**

Between two and three the meadow was dead. Rew had been right. The farrier's fire was banked and the tent rows were empty and there was a queue at the cook-tent forty yards off with every voice in the camp in it.

So she walked the lines with a barrel on her shoulder and counted properly.

Twenty-five tents in rows, and eleven of them cold. No gear out, no boots at the flaps, guy lines slack. On a freezing October afternoon with every chimney in Purewater going. Those men were in the city.

Forty-one horses, and eleven of those lame or resting, and the farrier with a pile of thrown shoes beside him that said he had been losing a fight since Anminster.

And down at the end, past the picket line, two young men in Purewater clothes were shovelling out a horse-line into a barrow.

*
**

She put the butt down where a butt might go, straightened up, and looked at the sky like a woman whose back hurt. Which it did.

The one who knew her kept shovelling and spoke to the muck.

"Don't." Barely moving his mouth. "He's been there since eleven."

Twenty feet off, a knight sat on a tack-box picking at a stitched seam on his sword-grip and had not looked up.

"You all right?"

“We’ve not been hit.” Shovel. Shovel. “We’ve not been let go either. They took the boats off us at four and they took *us* at four and nobody’s said a word about wages or when.”

Two more loads. The other lad had not looked up once.

“Tam,” he said eventually. Giving her his name, because he knew she would need it, and because she was the only person who had asked him anything all day.

And then, much quieter and a great deal faster:

“We were tied up asleep. There was a boat came down the channel about four. One man, poling it like he’d never held a pole, and he went past us *soaked through*. Head to foot. Coat and all, in October.”

Shovel.

“Didn’t stop. Went east, up the far side.”

Shovel.

He straightened to shift the barrow, and while his back was to the knight he said the last of it to the sky, in the same voice he’d have used about the weather.

“Kag, we never said we saw anything. Nobody asked us. They just came and got us.”

*
**

Twenty feet away the man on the tack-box had stopped picking at the seam.

So Kag stretched — which at her height takes a while and involves a good deal of shoulder — and then turned her head and cleared one nostril onto the grass, thoroughly, with a finger, in the manner of a woman who has never once in her life considered that anybody might be watching.

Then she looked at the sky again, spat, put the butt up on the other shoulder, and walked off up the lines.

It worked because it was always going to work. The knight watched about four seconds of it and went back to the seam, and by the time she was past the farrier's fire he had forgotten anything had happened, because nothing had: a labourer took a break, was disgusting, and went back to work.

She had been invisible for the first time in her life, it had cost her nothing, and she did not much like how it felt.

*
**

Rew did not answer straight away when she asked him to keep an eye on the two boys. He finished the coil, hung it, and started another one.

"I'll tell you if something happens to them." Carefully, and the care was the point. "I'll not go *asking*. I'm a chandler with a bad hip, and I sell tar to the man in the big tent and rope to your lot, and the day either of them thinks I'm doing anything else I'm finished at sixty with nothing."

He tied off the coil.

"But I'm at that landing every day and I see who goes down the lines and who comes back up. And if two Purewater lads stop coming back up, I'll know within the hour."

He looked at her properly for the first time since she had arrived.

"And I'll get word to Hessa the same day. Not to you — to Hessa, through the rope order, the way it's always gone. You never came out here and I never saw you and there's nothing on any paper anywhere."

A pause.

"That's the whole of what I'll do. Don't come back here, Kag."

It was not unfriendly. It was a man telling her the exact size of what he had, which was the most honest thing anybody had said to her in two days.

*
**

Hessa listened to the whole of it without writing anything down, which from her was alarming.

Then she said: "Say the numbers again."

"Twenty-five tents. Eleven cold. Forty-one horses, eleven of them lame."

"And no second company."

"No second company. There never was one. The one on the bridge told me four hundred, and I wrote four hundred down, and I built two days of work on it."

She sat back.

"That's the best thing anybody's brought him this year, and yesterday's four sheets was the best thing anybody'd brought him in a year, so I'm going to have to think of a new way of saying it."

*
**

Then the rest of it, and she went quiet for that.

"East," she repeated. "Four in the morning, soaked, poling like a farmhand, going *east*."

"East is the ship."

"East is the ship." She looked at the table. "And a Pearl boy running off the Pearl at four in the morning does not go east. There's nothing east for a Pearl boy. He goes home, or he goes to ground on the Shoals with people who'd hide him, and either way he goes *west*."

She got there about a second after Kag had.

"So it wasn't Randall."

*
**

And then the other end of it arrived, and took the temperature of that back room down several degrees.

“Kag. Your witness is standing in a horse-line on Vantt’s meadow with a man watching him, and he can’t come here, and you can’t go back there, and Rew won’t ask a single question.”

She counted it off on her fingers, which she never did.

Marisette had a man in a bag on the strength of three women’s memory of a face, on an island she had shut, with the whole water saying *that poor boy* sadly.

“He’s the boss,” Kag said. “We tell him first. Then if he’s willing, I’ll go and tell her.”

A beat.

“I’ve always wanted to visit the Pearl.”

Hessa did not laugh, but something happened at the corner of her mouth.

“You’d be the first of us through that door who wasn’t delivering something.”

*
**

Crowbill was not on the roof. Hessa sent two boys and he was in the back of the chandlery inside twenty minutes, which was the fastest Kag had ever seen him move and was a piece of information all by itself.

He heard the whole thing standing up.

The numbers first. He took those with nothing on his face at all, and at the end of them he said “Twenty-five,” once, to himself, and then nothing for a while.

Then the rest. The wet man. East. The hour. Six soldiers taking the only two witnesses off the water before breakfast.

When she was done he asked exactly three questions.

“The lad who told you — would he say it to somebody who wasn’t you?”

“Don’t know. He’s frightened and he’s in a field.”

“Mm. Second. Does Marisette know any part of this?”

“No.”

“Third.” He looked up. “Does anybody else know you were out east today?”

“Rew. And he’d rather chew his own leg off.”

He thought about it for a long time. Long enough that Hessa went back to work and the light through the shutter moved.

“Go and tell her. Tonight, before she does anything.”

He held up a hand before Kag had moved.

“And understand what you’re carrying, because it isn’t mercy and I’d rather you didn’t sell it as mercy. She’s about to kill a Pearl boy for something a di Teufel did, in front of her own people, on the word of three women who love him.”

“Got it, boss.” A beat. “Thank you.”

CHAPTER 7 — THE MOTHER OF PEARL



MARISSETTE HAD BEEN SITTING IN THE SAME CHAIR SINCE FOUR O'CLOCK THAT MORNING, in good cloth that was not louder than the room, with her hands still — and every other soul in that house had been on their feet for fourteen hours, and that was the entire arrangement, that was what twenty-two years of governing eleven houses on nothing but the settled expectation that she would still be there afterwards actually looked like from the inside. You sit. You do not hurry. And on the two or three occasions in a decade when somebody needs to find out what you are, you turn out to be worse than they imagined.

She had a girl four doors away with a wound running from her collarbone to her hip.

And she had a man in her cellar, taken off the quay before light on the word of three women who had known him since he was a child and who had all, independently, wept while giving it.

So the rumour was, at present, costing her rather more than she had ever paid for it.

*
**

Sten came up at dusk and said there was a half-orc at the back lane who would not go away, and that the half-orc was Crowbill's, and had brought an eleven-year-old boy with no shoes on.

“She says it’s about the fella in the bag.”

“Then bring her up.”

*
**

The woman filled the doorway and then, interestingly, declined to fill the room.

She stood where Sten put her — feet together, hands where they could be seen, eyes up. Like a soldier. And waited.

Hesper was against the wall by the shutter in plain dark clothes with empty hands, and had not made a sound since the stair, and the half-orc had not seen them and would not until they chose to move.

Marisette looked at her for a long moment, and what she was doing was not sizing her up. It was something more careful than that.

“Sit down.”

She indicated the chair with two fingers.

“You have been standing since you came in and it is making my girls nervous.” A pause, and the corner of her mouth moved. “Also you are blocking most of the light and I am too old to squint.”

There was a cup on the table by the chair that had been poured before she came up.

“Sten says you know something about the man in my cellar.” She folded her hands. “Take your time. Nobody is going anywhere tonight, and I have had a very long day, so you may have as much of it as you like.”

She smiled, and it was genuinely warm, and there was not one single thing in that room that was not comfortable.

The half-orc did not sit and did not touch the cup.

Marisette noticed both and mentioned neither.

*
**

She gave it the way you would read out a tally. In order. No colour anywhere in it, which after fourteen hours of a house full of people with colour was very nearly restful.

A man in a boat at four in the morning. One man, alone, poling it like he had never held a pole in his life, soaked head to foot — coat and all, in October. Past two moored lighters with two Purewater lads asleep aboard.

Not stopping.

East. Up the far side.

A witness's name. Where he had been. That an hour later six of the Baron's men had come onto the Guild landing and taken both of them off the water, and that they were at that moment shovelling out a horse-line on the Vantt meadow with a man sitting twenty feet away who was neither helping nor leaving, and that they had not been hit, not been charged, not been paid and not been let go.

And then she stopped.

That was the whole of it, and she did not ask for anything.

*
**

Marisette did not move at all.

It was Hesper who spoke, from the wall, mild and unhurried and entirely without weight.

"East is the ship."

"Yes," Marisette said.

"A boy off this island does not go east." Hesper had not moved. "He goes to the Shoals, or he goes to the Promise of Heaven where forty women would put him under a floor. There is nothing east for a Pearl boy but open water and a private pier."

*
**

And then the half-orc apologised for the light, and sat.

It took her a moment to do it and it took eight feet of her out of the middle of a small room, and Marisette watched her do it and felt something in her own shoulders ease very slightly.

“Because we don’t want you making a mistake by killing a boy from the Pearl when the cutter’s a di Teufel.” A beat. “Professional courtesy. Ma’am.”

“Professional courtesy,” Marisette repeated.

“Ma’am.”

“Mm.” She turned the phrase over once. “I have been in this trade forty-one years and that is the first time anybody has used those two words to me and meant them.”

*
**

She did not thank her. She did something better and a great deal faster.

“Hesper. Go down and let him out. Now, before we say another word, because I would rather he spent no further minutes in there on my account.”

Hesper was already off the wall.

“Take him up to the kitchen, not out the front. Get Ilsa to look at his wrists, and if there is a mark on him anywhere I want to know which of my people put it there before you come back up.”

At the door, Hesper paused.

“And tell him?”

“Tell him the truth.” Flatly. “That I had him taken on the word of three women who love him. That I was wrong. That I will say so in this house and on that quay and anywhere else he wants me to, and that he may have anything he asks me for by way of it.”

A pause.

“And that I am sorry, in those words. And that he does not have to accept it.”

The door closed.

*
**

Then it was the two of them and a lamp and a cup nobody had drunk.

“A di Teufel,” Marisette said. “You said the cutter’s a di Teufel. Crowbill sent you here to tell me that.”

“He did not.”

And Marisette, who had been lied to professionally by experts on four continents and had spent twenty-two years knowing which of her girls was lying and exactly why, had it inside half a second — and what surprised her was not the lie.

It was that the woman had gone to the trouble.

She laughed. Once, and not unkindly.

Then she leaned over and turned the lamp *up* — which put the light on both of them instead of only on the half-orc — and sat back.

“Mm.”

She let that be all of it, for long enough that the music starting up down the quay became audible through the shutter.

“He’s a careful man,” she said. “I’ve always liked him.”

She stood, which meant the half-orc stood, and went to the shutter and opened it a crack. All the lamps lit out there now, the whole necklace of them, and somebody tuning something badly.

Behind her a woman of seven feet was putting a chair back exactly where she had found it, which nobody who came into that room ever did.

*
**

“There was chalk on the floor of that room. Under a rug.” She was not looking at her. “Corners on it. Half finished.”

A beat.

“And a knife behind the armoire. Constantine’s left it where it fell, which is more sense than the council’s got between them.”

She closed the shutter.

“Somebody in this city made that. Or moved it. Or was offered it and said no.”

A beat.

“You strike me as a woman who knows where things come from.”

“I am. Very much so.” No hesitation anywhere in it. “Would you like us to look into this matter?”

Marisette turned round.

“Yes.”

She looked at her for a second.

“Not for me. Don’t bring it to me — I’ve enough that I can’t use.” A pause. “Bring it to him, and let him decide what it’s worth.”

*
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She opened the door.

Down the passage there was noise coming up from the kitchen. A great many voices at once, and a woman crying, and somebody laughing with it, which is what that sounds like when it goes right.

“Sten will put you across. Take the boy home.”

At the head of the stair she stopped.

“Kag.”

It was the first time she had used it.

“If anyone on this island is ever unhelpful to you, say my name to them once.”

Then she went down toward the kitchen and the noise, and did not look back, and that is a thing she had done perhaps four times in twenty-two years and never once for somebody who had come in through the back lane.

CHAPTER 8 — WHAT COLOUR IS THE RUG



PELL WOKE UP THE WAY BOYS DO, all at once and in the middle of a sentence, in the bottom of Sten's boatman's skiff at the Lullwater stair with a stranger's coat over him.

"—she's not dead because of a woman."

Kag stopped with one foot on the stone.

He rubbed his face and got it into order, because he had been carrying it since noon and nobody had asked him for it.

"I went and I asked like you said. Not who cut her. Who *mended* her." He was extremely pleased with himself and trying not to show it. "Kitchen girl at the Lily Garden said. There's a woman been taken on at the Sylph's this week — foreign, elf, come in off the landward road. And she's got a *wolf*."

He held his hands out to show how big, which was not accurate.

"They put her on the water-stair all night and when the screaming started she was up them stairs before anybody. Kitchen girl says she went in the room and put everybody out and shut the door, and when Sister Ansel come at half four the girl was already stopped bleeding."

He looked up.

"Kitchen girl says it weren't stitching. She says nobody stops that with stitching."

A shrug, because he was eleven and that was the end of what he knew.

“That’s all I got. Is it good?”

It was good.

It was the second time that day that the thing she needed had come from somebody nobody was looking at.

*
**

The hall of the Sylph’s Embrace smelled of lye. Somebody had been scrubbing the flags with a will since before dark and had not got all of it up.

Constantine came out of the kitchen with her sleeves past the elbow and a cloth in her hand. She had not slept. She looked at eight feet of half-orc in her doorway with two of Marisette’s men standing behind it, and her face did not change by one degree.

“No.”

She said it the way you say it to rain.

“I’ve had the Watch, I’ve had the Order, I’ve had four of Marisette’s and a man from the council’s clerk, and every one of them wanted to see the room and not one of them wanted to see *her*.” The cloth went over her shoulder. “So. No.”

She did not move out of the doorway.

“Who are you?”

“Kag. Crowbill’s.”

“Mm.” Something shifted, fractionally. Not warmer. “Then you’ll want the knife.”

She had already worked it out and did not look pleased about being right.

“Go on, then. What’s it going to cost me, having you upstairs?”

“Nothing. I’ll be quick. I just need to find out where it came from — maybe take a rubbing or two, to check details.”

A beat.

“People misjudge me, you know. I hate it when they do that.”

*
**

Constantine looked at her for a second longer than was comfortable.

“Mm,” she said.

Then she took the cloth off her shoulder, folded it, and put it down on the hall table, which was a thing she did not need to do and which took four seconds.

“One condition. You don’t go in there thinking about a knife.”

She picked up a lamp.

“You go in remembering there was a girl on that floor. Everybody’s been up those stairs today and not one of them has been able to tell me what colour the rug is.”

She was already going up.

“Sister Ansel’s asleep in the chair and Emmeralda’s under. You wake either of them and we’re done.”

*
**

First floor, the end door. A day, and nobody had touched anything, because the woman who owned that house had more sense than the entire city council and had kept it shut.

The lamp went down on the floor where the light was useful, which was somebody’s habit from the night before.

The bed shoved back against the wall. A window, closed now, and latched. Two glasses on the sill and one of them still full.

A rug kicked half over, and under the edge of it, chalk — big, and the part you could see had *corners* on it.

Bare boards where the rug was not, scrubbed hard and not scrubbed enough, and a long dark stain in the grain running downhill toward the window with two handprints in it at the top.

A man's coat over the back of the chair by the washstand. Good cloth. Too warm for the season.

And the armoire, standing a foot out from the wall where two people had walked it out the night before.

The rug was green. A dark green, with a border, and worn through in one place by the foot of the bed where somebody had stood to dress for fifteen years.

*
**

She did not pick the knife up.

She got down on the boards with her cheek nearly on the floor and worked it out from where it lay, and when she moved it she moved it with the back of a knife of her own — a quarter-turn, so the pommel came into the lamplight.

Paper off the back of Constantine's ledger. A stub of charcoal. The rubbing took four goes, because the boards were not flat, and the fourth came out clean.

What anybody could have seen: about eleven inches, barbed down one edge — not serrated, *barbed*, small swept-back hooks like fish-hooks, which are not for killing anything and are for opening something slowly and holding it open while you work. A groove down the flat. The grip wound with something dark that was not leather and that she elected not to think about. Blood gone black and tacky on the hooks.

And set into the pommel, small and beautifully done: a ring with a line through it and three strokes off the line.

What she could *not* do was price it, and that stopped her flat.

She had valued nine years of cargo. Salt fish, hemp, tallow, iron-mongery, contraband glass, one shipment of stolen brass fittings that

took a week. She could put a figure on almost anything that crossed that water to within about ten per cent and had never once been badly wrong.

She had no comparables for this. None. It sat outside every single thing she knew, which had not happened to her since she was nineteen.

*
**

Nobody had looked in the fireplace.

Four people up those stairs in a day and not one of them had looked in the grate, and what came out of it came out in three pieces and a great deal of black that went to nothing between her fingers: two palm-sized pieces of heavy paper scorched brown at the margins and still cream in the centre, and a third the size of a playing card.

Written on. Not printed — a dense sloping hand in brown ink with the letters run together, and among the lines, drawn small and exact, figures. One of them was a ring with a line through it and three strokes off the line, twice over.

The same mark as the pommel.

And the hand was a grown man's. Confident, fast, practised. Not the hand of a nineteen-year-old who has never had to do anything twice.

Constantine held them to the hall lamp and turned one over and her face did not change.

"I've had four people up those stairs today and not one of them looked in the fireplace."

She handed them back.

"Keep it. If it's in my house it's evidence against my house, and I've got a ledger for the rest."

Then, flatly, without looking up:

“Write down that you took it and when. I’ll countersign. I’m not having a thing turn up in a year that nobody can account for.”

And that — a scrubbed hall at nine o’clock at night, a woman with her sleeves past her elbows and a ledger she did standing up, and a line of provenance written in two hands — was the most dangerous object anybody in Purewater produced that week, and neither of them knew it.

*
**

“I’d like to meet the healer.”

That got the first proper pause of the evening out of her.

“Would you.”

She pushed off the door and picked the lamp back up and stood there weighing it, and what she was weighing was not Kag.

“She’s been awake thirty hours and she’s got a wolf in my yard that won’t drink out of the canal.”

A beat.

“Wrong sort of elf.”

And then, after a second, and plainly finding it difficult:

“Gardwen.”

CHAPTER 9 — THE FOURTH OF JUNE



HILD OF ORSK & DAUGHTER PUT ONE BLUNT FINGER ON THE RUBBING AND SAID *THAT'S MINE*, and she did not sound frightened and she did not sound sorry — she sounded like a craftsman looking at her own work lying somewhere it had no business being, which is a particular kind of anger and takes about forty years to develop.

Pell had got her inside an hour and a half.

He was extremely good at it. He went in with his hands empty and said it the same way every time — *Kag'd like to know who cut this, please* — and showed the slip and touched nothing. Three men sent him off. The fourth came to the door herself with the rubbing held up close to her eyes, looked down the founders' lane, found Kag on the cookshop bench, and jerked her head once.

Inside it was hot and dark with four hundred pounds of copper sheet stacked against one wall.

"Pommel-cut, nine weeks back. Somebody's drawing, not mine."

"Nobody's dead," Kag said. "Close, though. A lordling tried to gut a girl at the Sylph's Embrace last night and got interrupted, and a healer saved her." A beat. "Let me guess. The dragonshits."

Hild listened to the whole of it without moving.

"Girl live?"

“She lived.”

“Right.” She turned the slip over in her hands. “Then you can have it.”

*
**

She went to the ledger first, because dwarves go to the ledger first. Chained to the bench, four generations in it. She ran a finger down a column, and her face changed.

“I said nine weeks. That’s wrong — I was going off the job and not off the book.”

She turned it round and tapped the line.

4 June.

“Four months back.”

They both looked at that for a second.

“Nobody in this city had heard of any baron in June,” Hild said.

*
**

“And no. Not one of theirs, or not that I could tell, and I’d have noticed.”

She handed the slip over at last.

“Purewater man. Fifties, grey, dressed like a steward — *good* clothes, not gentleman’s clothes, the sort a big house puts its people in. Came in on a Tuesday, put the drawing on that bench, paid the whole lot up front in city coin, and asked me how long.”

A shrug.

“Never gave a name. Never had to — he paid up front and it’s a pommel-cut. It’s an afternoon’s work.” She nodded at the slip. “He came back nine days later and collected and I’ve not seen him since. And that’s his drawing, not my copy. He left it.”

A beat.

“Which I thought was careless at the time.”

Kag unfolded it, and there was the mark — and around it, in a dense sloping hand in brown ink, four lines of writing.

The same hand as the three burnt pieces in her shirt.

*
**

“Anything distinctive about him? Something I could put the word out on.”

Hild thought about it properly, which took a while, and she thought about *hands*, because that is what forty years at a bench does to a person.

“Nothing off his face. Grey, clean-shaven, ordinary. You’d walk past him.” She held her own hands up. “His hands, though. Big writing callus, here — second finger, right hand, built up hard. That’s not a servant’s hand. That’s a man who writes all day.”

She lowered them.

“And this is the bit I’ve thought about since, because I didn’t like it at the time.”

She tapped her own chest.

“His coat had been re-buttoned.”

She saw the question and answered it before it came.

“Buttons don’t sit where the old ones did. Cloth gets a shine and a dent where a button’s sat five, six years, and his new ones were a half-inch off the marks all the way down. Somebody had taken a set off that coat and put plain ones on, and not long before, because the old dents hadn’t relaxed.”

She let it stand.

“Now. A man takes the buttons off a coat for one reason.”

Behind her somebody dropped something metal and swore in Dwarvish and nobody reacted.

“Whatever house dresses its people well enough to have its own buttons — that’s who he came from. And he knew it, and he did

something about it before he walked in here.” A beat. “And he still didn’t think to take the drawing home.”

*
**

“Thank you. We’ll remember this.”

Hild waved it off with the back of her hand.

“Don’t remember it. That’s how it starts.” She was already turning back to the bench. “A girl lived. That’ll do me.”

And at the door, without looking round:

“If you find him — you’ll not bring it back through here.”

“No.”

“Good.”

*
**

Hessa had the tally out before Kag had sat down, because she had been at it since six as well.

“Say it.”

The workshop. The date. The buttons. She wrote all of it and reacted to none of it, and at *fourth of June* her pen stopped for about half a second and then carried on.

Then the Pearl, and she put the pen down.

She did not need Kag’s book. She had her own and she had been at it two hours.

“Eleven bridges. Forty-one a day, on your own figures, and getting worse on your curve.” She turned the page. “Pearl. Eleven houses, four hundred and eleven people, the boats, the drink, the card-rooms, and everything that gets said in a room on that island and comes back to us.” She tapped the column. “Four hundred and six a day. On the first day. It goes up, because the boats that served it are idle too.”

She sat back.

“Ten times the bridges. In one morning.”

A beat.

“And it wasn’t the Knights that did it. It was *her*, and she did it on purpose, and she’ll hold it as long as she can stand to.”

The room was quiet for a while. Somebody was moving barrels in the yard.

“Right,” Hessa said. “I’ll say it, because you’re going to have to write it down and I’d rather you heard it out loud first.”

Flatly. No weight on it at all.

“The cheapest thing he can do is settle with the Baron.”

*
**

She had shut eleven houses on one sentence, and the sentence was *until the man who cut Emmeralda is in a cell*.

Four hundred and eleven people. Three days of her own money, and counting.

And on the far side of High Isle, on a ship that steamed where its hull met the water, behind twenty men and a pier no ferryman would row past, there was a nineteen-year-old with rings on three fingers who had stood on Pearl Quay in daylight and told an entire street he would burn that house with the girls inside it.

Thirty witnesses. Some of them had it by nightfall as *the girls inside and the doors nailed*, which is how it goes.

He would come back for her. He had said so in front of a crowd.

*
**

The presentation was on Temple Isle on the eve of the Tourney, and by long form every entrant in every event is walked out in front of the Crown’s man, names read, colours shown, and each of them **bare-headed for the space of a bow**.

Kag had very nearly forgotten it, and should not have.

She went to say goodbye to the elf in Constantine's yard and found her sitting where she had been sitting for two days, looking at a gate, with a wolf beside her that would not drink out of the canal.

"Hey. Girl."

Gardwen did not look up straight away. When she did it was slow, like somebody surfacing.

"Cheer up. Go and see the presentation — they walk the lot of them out on Temple Isle this afternoon, colours and names and bowing. Half the city goes. It's free." Kag shrugged the coat on. "Might do you good. You've been sat in a yard looking at a gate for two days."

"...There's a presentation?"

"Every entrant. Bare-headed for the bow, that's the form of it. My mother's people used to do the same at the beast-fairs, only with fewer bows and a lot more shouting."

And Gardwen looked at the gate, and then at the wolf, and then — for the first time since Kag had met her — at *herself*: the state of her hands, the front of her, two days of it.

"I'd have to wash."

"You would."

Something that was almost a laugh came out of her.

"All right."

From the kitchen door, with a pan in her hand and not the slightest interest in pretending she had not been listening to every word:

"Good. I'll come."

*
**

Six hundred people on the grass on Temple Isle, and the di Teufel colours came out about two-thirds down the list.

The Baron first, bare-headed on purpose — uncovered and unhurried, letting six hundred people look at him for as long as they liked. And the crowd looked.

Then the champion.

Walked out in full harness with a man at each shoulder. The herald read something. And the helm came off for the space of a bow.

He was too thin for it.

That was what everybody on that grass saw and nobody remarked on, because armour never fits anybody and nobody cares. Seventeen, perhaps. A long neck. And he held the bow about a second longer than the form required, and one of the men at his shoulder put a hand flat on the backplate to bring him up.

Then the helm went back on and it was over, and the herald was already on the next name, and six hundred people clapped the way a crowd claps at the forty-first name on a list.

*

**

Forty yards up the slope, Gardwen had not moved.

She had both hands on the rope. She was not shaking and she was not making a sound and she had not taken a breath since the helm came off, and Magda had a hand on her upper arm and was saying something into the side of her head.

And that was genuinely all Kag could see.

Nine years of reading people for money — across a bench, across a bridge, across a table with a lamp on it — and she stood forty yards from a woman having the worst four seconds of her life and got absolutely nothing at all.

CHAPTER 9 — A LETTER IN HER OWN HAND



EMMERALDA HAD BEEN WANTED BY EVERYBODY FOR FIFTEEN YEARS and asked what she wanted by almost nobody, and the great private joke of her life — the one she had never told a soul, not the girls, not Constantine, certainly not any of the men who wrote her poetry — was that she had been counting. Not money. Years. She had decided at twenty-two that she would give it until she was thirty-eight and then she would stop, and go somewhere with water and no lamps, and feed cats, and never again be the most interesting thing in a room.

She had two years left on that count when a nineteen-year-old opened her from the collarbone to the hip with a barbed knife because she had laughed at him.

On the Thursday morning she had been awake since six, and she had spoiled ten sheets of paper.

*
**

The trouble was not the words. The trouble was that every version she wrote was a version of herself, and she had been performing versions of herself for fifteen years, and she could do the frightened one and the yearning one and the sly one in her sleep — and every single one of them read, when she looked at it in the grey light with her ruined hair hanging in her eyes, like a woman writing a love letter to the man who had cut her.

Which it was. That was the point. That was precisely and exactly the point, and knowing it did not help at all.

Sheet six had got as far as *my dear*.

Sheet nine had two words on it.

Gardwen sat on the boards beside the chair with her knees up and did not say anything for hours at a time, and the wolf lay across the landing, and the grey cat that had followed her home in the spring sat on the sill with its feet folded under it as though nothing whatsoever had happened, which was, if she was honest, the only company she could stand.

Then the door went, and the half-orc came in.

*

**

She was enormous and she stood too far inside the room the way big people do when they are trying not to loom and are therefore looming in a new place, and she put a silver hair-comb down on the table beside the inkwell.

His comb. Dusty in the teeth from wherever Marisette had been keeping it.

Emmeralda stopped writing and looked at it.

There was nothing on her head any more to put it in. She had done that herself on Tuesday with a kitchen knife, sitting on this floor, and she had no memory at all of deciding to.

She looked at the comb anyway, for considerably longer than it took.

Then she pulled the coat closed at her throat with one hand and went back to the page, because if she looked at it one second more she was going to do something with it that she would have to explain.

“He’ll want to know I kept it hidden from Constantine,” she said. “That’s the part he’ll like.”

And then, because she had nothing left and this woman had at least brought the thing instead of sending it:

“Tell me something I can write that only he knows.”

*
**

“I can’t help you there,” the half-orc said.

Emmeralda waited, because waiting was a professional skill and she had eighteen years of it.

“If you want something off me it’ll be numbers of people crossing bridges,” Kag said, “or what a house takes in a night off one room, or what a boat of Anminster wool is worth at the Guild landing on a Tuesday against a Friday. That’s what I’ve got.” A shrug of enormous shoulders. “You’re the only person alive who knows the man. I do need the letter soon, mind. There’s the whole of it to set up.”

And Emmeralda laughed.

It came out of her before she could stop it and it was a horrible, cracked, unused sound, and it was the first laugh in that room in four days, and Gardwen’s head came up off her knees at the sound of it.

Bridges.

Of course. Of *course*. She had been sitting here since six o’clock trying to write herself, and what was actually wanted was a piece of work — a thing with a job to do, costed, delivered, the way you would order rope.

“Bridges,” she said. “All right, then.”

After that she wrote fast and did not stop, and the paper kept trying to lift off the table in the draught until Gardwen got up without a word and pulled the far window down to a hand’s width and sat back down again.

Four lines. Six. She turned it over and did three more on the back.

What she put in it was this, and she gave it to the half-orc plainly, because there was no version of saying it that improved with softening:

“He told me I’d be out of this house inside a year, and I laughed at him.” She blotted it with the heel of her hand rather than wait for sand, because she was not going to sit in front of these two waiting for sand. “I’ve put that he was right. That I shouldn’t have laughed. That I can get out for an hour after the bell tonight and that I’m frightened of Constantine.”

A beat.

“Every word of that is true except the last one, and he’ll believe the last one hardest, because it’s the one that makes him the rescue.”

She folded it twice and pressed the crease flat with her thumbnail and held it out, and the coat fell open at the throat and she did not bother with it that time.

“Who’s carrying it?”

*
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The half-orc asked who had carried the others, and Emmeralda answered before she had finished hearing the question, which is how she knew she had been dreading it since dawn.

“Ila. Both times.” The pen went down flat on the table. “And you’re not having her.”

The window Gardwen had left at a hand’s width whistled a little.

Gardwen was not looking at Emmeralda any more. Gardwen was looking at the door.

Ila was in it.

Thirteen years old, elven, thin as a rope, barefoot on cold boards with a jug of water somebody had sent her for, and she had plainly been standing on that landing with the wolf for some time.

“I took the first one in a basket of his own shirts, back to the barge landing,” Ila said, with no particular weight on any of it. “The second I gave to the boy in the green coat at the Fishmarket end, because he’d started coming that way.”

She looked at the folded paper in Kag’s hand.

“He never looked at me once.”

*
**

There was an argument after that and Emmeralda lost it, and she lost it because the child was right and because the half-orc did not once raise her voice and because Ila, who had no social reflexes at all and had never in her life softened anything for anybody, simply put her hand out and asked whether she was going.

Nobody had ever asked Ila for anything either. That was the whole trouble with this house. That was the whole trouble with the entire island, come to that, and Emmeralda had spent fifteen years not saying so.

She got up. It took her longer than it should have and she did it without holding on to anything, because she was not going to hold on to anything in front of a child.

And then she did the only thing left that was hers to do.

She crossed the room and took the comb out of the half-orc’s hand before it got to the girl, and wrapped it in one of the spoiled sheets, folding the ends over the way you wrap a fish, and put it into Ila’s palm with the letter on top of it, and closed the child’s fingers around both of them and held them shut.

“Don’t wait for him to read it.”

That was the whole of it. Eighteen years of being the finest performer on the Pearl and that was the only useful thing she had ever had to teach anybody.

She went back to her chair and sat down, and she did that carefully too.

Ila had already put the bundle inside her shift and was gone down the stairs with her bare feet not making any sound at all, past a wolf who lifted her head and put it down again.

Emmeralda picked up the pen, looked at the ten spoiled sheets, and began to tidy them into a stack, because her hands wanted something and there was nothing else on the table.

She was still doing it when the light changed.

CHAPTER 10 — THE LANDING



ILA HAD BEEN TOLD TO BE SOMEWHERE ELSE FOR FOUR DAYS, by adults who were managing their own grief so badly that they had entirely failed to notice she was managing hers alone, on a step, in the cold, where she could see the front door — and she had decided, at some point on the Wednesday, without telling anybody, that she was going to do something about it.

She was thirteen. She had lived at the Sylph's Embrace since she was nine. Emmeralda had taught her to read out of a book of shipping notices because it was the only book in the house that wasn't filthy, and had fed her every single night for four years without once making a performance of it, and had cried in front of her exactly twice, and had never, not once, told her to go and be somewhere else.

So on Thursday morning, when the enormous grey woman came up the stairs and the room went quiet in that particular way that means adults are about to arrange something without you, Ila stood in the doorway with a jug she hadn't been sent for and said the true thing, which was that he had never once looked at her.

Nobody argued with it, which surprised her.

She got her shoes.

*
**

The Long Butts had four thousand people on it by noon and every single one of them was complaining about the wind, which was coming off the open water across the range instead of along it and had been doing it since before light.

Ila went up the slope with a basket of somebody else's washing on her hip — three different houses' linen in one basket, which was the sort of detail that never mattered and this once did — and she went slowly, and she stopped twice, and she watched.

That was the whole of what Kag had told her. *Don't hurry, don't be clever, and look at the ground before you walk on it.*

The ground was this: a stone quay at the west end where the slope ran out, nine steps down to the water, a bollard line, and four thousand people who were all, in about two hours, going to want it at the same moment.

The household box was black with six chairs and five of them were full.

He was in the one on the right, forward in the seat with his elbows on the rail, watching the shooting like a boy at a fair, and he was nineteen years old and quite beautiful and he had opened Emmeralda up the length of her body with a barbed knife, and Ila looked at him for a long time from forty feet away in a crowd of four thousand and felt nothing whatsoever except a great and useful clarity.

The wide grey man stood on the stone below the box and read the crowd in slow sweeps, left to right, the way you read a page.

*

**

The elf in plain harness won the archery, which Ila did not really watch, and afterwards there were ninety seconds in front of the Governor's box where four thousand people leaned forward and waited for something.

The elf took the wreath and said eleven words and walked off the grass.

The slope didn't know what to do with that and cheered anyway, and Ila thought, with the ruthlessness available only to the very young: *you had them and you didn't use it.*

Then the horn went for the close, and four thousand people stood up at once and started thinking about the water, and it happened exactly the way the half-orc had said it would at dawn.

They came off the slope. The landing took forty at a time. The boats were not ready and were never going to be ready, because Purewater boatmen have never in the history of that city been ready for anybody in a hurry. And the household came down onto the stone with everybody else and stood in it — the Baron with two knights at his shoulder, and the son three feet from a fishmonger's wife with a live crab in a bag.

Ila went in from the bollard side.

She came up on his blind side, which is the side away from the water, because a man on a quay watches the water. The bundle went from her hand to his without either of them looking down at it. He closed his fingers on it out of pure reflex, the way a man takes a note at a party.

She was four people away before he'd understood he was holding anything.

It was perfect. It was absolutely perfect, and she knew it was perfect, and she was eleven feet clear and already composing how she would tell Bett about it.

And then there was a hand around the top of her arm.

*
**

He did not grab her. That was the thing she would think about afterwards, on and off, for years. He put his hand round her arm the way you take hold of a gate — no squeeze in it, no shake — and turned her to face him, and crouched slightly so that his eyes were level with hers, which no adult had done to her since she was seven.

Up close he was thin and white-skinned and red-eyed with old burn down one side of his face into the collar, and he smelled of nothing at all.

“What’s your name?”

And Ila, who had no social reflexes, who did not move aside for people, who did not soften things and had never learned to perform, heard herself say: “Ila.”

“Where are you taking that washing, Ila?”

“The Promise of Heaven.”

Which was a lie, and it was a good lie, and it came out of her flat and unblinking — and she watched him receive it, and file it, and not believe it, all without moving his face at all.

“That’s not true,” he said, without any unkindness whatsoever. “But I’m not going to do anything about it, because I have hold of a child in a crowd and that is not a thing I do.”

Eight seconds. That was the whole of it. Eight seconds and a name.

*
**

What saved her was the water, and the water was not an accident.

Somewhere behind her in the press the whole landing lurched — forty people going forward at once because a boat had finally come alongside — and a woman two along from the grey man lost the stone entirely and went in between the hull and the steps with a shriek and a great green gout of canal.

Three men grabbed. The grey man let go of Ila’s arm and took the woman’s wrist and hauled her out one-handed onto the stone like a man landing a net, and set her on her feet, and looked around.

Ila was already gone, over the Fishmarket bridge and home by the back of the ice-houses, running the way she had been taught by nobody at all.

She was sick twice on the way, behind the ice-houses, quietly, and then went in the water door and up the back stairs and sat down on the second-floor landing with her arms round the wolf, who put up with it.

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Out on the water, the household's boat pulled for High Isle. A nineteen-year-old sat in the stern with one hand flat inside his coat, looking at the wake and not at anybody, already composing the rest of his life.

And on the stones the wide grey man stood a while in the thinning crowd with his hat in his hands, turning over a name he had been given for nothing by a child who had lied to him about everything else.

He did not use it that day. He did not use it the next day either.

He was extremely good at his job, and the worst thing about him — the thing that made him worse than any of the men with swords — was that he never once had to hurry.

CHAPTER 11 — NINE STEPS



KAG HAD NEVER IN HER LIFE RUN ANYTHING, and standing at the top of the Lily Garden's back water-stair in the dark with a wet rope in her hand and six people's evenings arranged around a thing she had thought of on Tuesday, she discovered that the sensation was not power at all. It was closer to being very cold. Every part of it was somebody else's body. Tess on the fourth step in Emmeralda's grey. Hesper eight feet below in a boat with a rod propped up, pretending to fish, in a coat and a hat and a complete absence of anything describable. Deri and Fen on the stone at the top, forty feet apart, arguing quietly about a horse in the way of two married men who had been told to look bored and were overdoing it.

The whole plan was made of people, and people are not rope, and you cannot test them beforehand.

The stair itself was four feet of wet stone and nine steps down to a dead end, with a gate at the top you could lift off its pins with one hand, and there was no lamp past the gate, which was the entire reason it had been chosen.

And then it was the waiting, which is the part nobody puts in the stories.

The water slapped. Somebody two houses over was having precisely the same argument they had been having the night before. The wet line came up out of the dark from Hesper's hand to hers and

she could feel the boat breathe on it, once every few seconds, like something asleep.

Full dark, and she could see all of it, because she always could.

*
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Twenty minutes past the bell a skiff came up from the seaward end with no lamp on it, moving slow, three people in it.

Two of them were poling, one fore and one aft, standing up and easy with it — Purewater men, because nobody out of a country with roads stands up in a boat — and the third sat amidships with a cloak up over his head.

At twenty feet the cloak came off, because he could not help wanting to see the steps.

Nineteen. Dark hair. A plain brown thing over something that had cost a great deal more, and one hand flat inside the front of it.

And the man on the aft pole was Tam.

Tam. Off the Guild landing, four o'clock Thursday morning, not seen on this water since, with a wife who had stood on wet stone since six. Standing up in that boat poling the Baron's son to a dead-end stair and looking back over his shoulder the whole way up the canal like a man being marched.

There is a particular kind of anger that arrives without heat and simply rearranges what you are prepared to do.

Kag pulled the line.

*
**

It came tight, and somewhere below her in the dark Hesper said one word — not loudly, the way you say a name across a room — and Tess went over sideways on the fourth step with her cheek on the stone, out, breathing, exactly as advertised.

Santo di Teufel did not.

He stood there a second and a half looking at a girl who had just fallen asleep at his feet at the bottom of a dead-end stairwell, and then he ran, and he ran the *wrong way* — down, at the water, because the top of the steps had two men on it and because water had been the way out of everything his entire life.

Kag came down nine wet steps.

He got one foot onto the gunwale of Hesper's skiff and the skiff did what a skiff does under one foot, and then there was a forearm across his chest and that was the whole of it. Ten stone of nineteen-year-old in a very good coat. He kicked once and gave it up, and the letter came out of the front of his coat with the comb still folded in the spoiled page.

Hesper had already sat back down and picked up the rod.

Six feet away Tam stood in the other boat with the pole in his hands and his mouth open, and he had known Kag eleven years.

She winked at him over the top of the boy's head.

Tam shut his mouth, and after a moment jerked his chin about a quarter of an inch, and turned his face out to the canal like a man who has come out to look at the weather.

*
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They had a room ready off the landing at the Mother of Pearl with a stone floor and a drain in the middle of it, because it was where they washed the linen, and one chair carried in from somewhere else.

He went into it hard enough that it moved.

Marisette came in behind and did not hurry and sat down on a stool by the wall and arranged her skirts as though it were any other Thursday in any other room in her house. Fen put the lamp on the floor and the light went up the walls, which made it worse, and Kag noticed him do it and thought: *you have done this before*.

Emmeralda walked the four doors herself.

She came in the big coat with her hair off at the jaw, and asked to be let in, and Kag looked at her for a second and then opened the door, and that was a decision that Kag would turn over a great many times afterwards and never once regret.

He heard the door and looked up expecting the madame.

And his whole face changed — not fear, the other thing, the worse thing — and he came forward against the cord as far as it let him and made a sound through the gag that had a shape to it, and the shape was her name, and he did it three times.

He thought the letter had worked.

He thought she had come.

Emmeralda stood in the doorway and looked at him with the lamp on him, and then she said, quite evenly, “Take that out of his mouth.”

*
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They took it out and he worked his jaw twice and there was a red line across both cheeks.

“Em.” His voice had not finished breaking, which was the single most obscene thing in that room. “I got your letter.”

Then he waited. He genuinely *waited*, with his hands tied behind a chair on a wet stone floor, the way you wait for somebody to pass you the salt.

She crossed the stone and stopped a yard in front of him.

“It wasn’t meant to be like that,” he said, low and fast, as though the two of them were alone and everybody else were furniture he hadn’t got round to. “You know it wasn’t.”

She went on looking at him.

“I can still take you out of here. Tonight. I’ve got the boat.”

And Emmeralda unfastened the coat.

She did not do it quickly and she did not do it for effect. She opened it and held it open and stood there in a shift in a cold room, and the

line he had put down her went from her collarbone to her hip, closed now, and pink, and perfectly straight, and there was a very great deal of it.

He turned his head away.

She waited.

He turned his head away again, and she waited again, and the third time he looked, because there was nowhere in that room that was not her.

Then she closed the coat and held it shut at the throat with one hand, the way she had all day, and walked out past Kag and stopped in the doorway with her back to the room.

"He's about five foot nine," she said, and went up the stairs.

*
**

Crowbill was in the back of an ice-house on the Shoals at two in the morning with a lamp and a blanket over his knees, because that is where Crowbill was at two in the morning, and he heard the whole of it and did not interrupt once.

Then he named his price, and it was not what she had been braced for.

"When Marisette has him in a chair, I want the asking. The Baron on a boat and gone inside the week, and not one word said out loud about anybody's face." A beat. "And you'll be the one who tells the two of them that. Not me."

So Kag went back and told them, whole, including the part that took everything away from them, and Marisette held her glass halfway up for about as long as it takes a cat to cross a room and then drank it.

"Eleven houses are going to ask me why we opened and nothing was said," she said. "And I shall have to let them think what they think."

Emmeralda did not come off the wall through any of it.

*
**

And later, in the ice-house again, Kag gave him the other half, and this was the part where she stopped being a person who costs things and became something she did not have a word for.

“He’s not going to trade for that boy,” she said. “He’s got a champion and a city to take and one son he has never in nine weeks been seen to like, and if we hand the boy back the only thing we’ve bought is his attention. He won’t pay. He’ll remember. And then in about a month he’ll come and find every single person who touched it, starting with the ones who can’t afford a door.”

“Then what?”

“Then Marisette gets her answers out of him. And then he’s fish food. And the twelve of us go on knowing that he rode out of this city with a girl — which two bridges of people watched happen on Tuesday night, and every one of them believes it, because Randall wore the coat and Tess wore the grey and nobody had to be told to lie about anything.”

The ice ticked and settled somewhere behind him in the dark.

“Not the Lullwater,” Crowbill said at last. “The pots are off the Lost Isle and the men who lift them are mine and they don’t look in.”

He trimmed the lamp without looking at it.

“And you’ll do it yourself. Not Deri. Not Fen. Not some fellow I’d have to pay and then worry about for eleven years.” He was entirely pleasant about it, the way he had been all week. “Eleven people can carry a story about a boy who ran off with a girl. Twelve people cannot carry a murder. So it’s one pair of hands, and they’re yours.”

Kag said of course, and that she didn’t mind that at all, and gave him the best orc smile she had.

She had never killed anybody in her life.

CHAPTER 12 — THE ICE RUN



KAG HAD EXPECTED IT TO BE HARDER, and the thing she was not prepared for — the thing nobody warns you about, because the people who could warn you have all made a private arrangement not to discuss it — was how ordinary it was, and how completely the world declined to mark it.

He went down into the boat still in a girl's blue cloak with his feet bare, and he did not fight, because it had not yet occurred to him that there was anything to fight. He had been told nothing. He had spent four hours in a chair on a wet floor being asked questions by a mage in plain clothes who never once raised their voice, and he had answered all of them, at length, eagerly, the way a clever boy answers a tutor, because being asked about his father's work was the closest thing to affection anybody had offered him in a year.

Out past the last of the Pearl the light came up grey off the water. The Lost Isle was a low green nothing with a fringe of poles in the shallows where the pots were set. Nobody lives on it. The men who lift the pots come at nine.

He asked one question on the way over, about halfway.

"Is my father paying?"

She did not answer him, and after a while he stopped expecting one, and then he sat and watched the water go past exactly the way anybody does.

It was quick, and it was done from behind, and he did not see it coming.

*
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The rest of it was work, and it is a strange mercy of this world that work is always available to a person who needs the next ten minutes to have a shape.

There is a gutting board on the stilt-shed that the pot-men use, and a knife on a lanyard, and a bucket. The pots went down full and heavy on the far string where the water runs deep and cold. The blue cloak went down with a stone in it somewhere else entirely, because you never put two things in one place. The board got three buckets of seawater and a scrub with sand and another three buckets.

The tide turned while she was washing her arms.

And that was all. There was no thunder. No gull did anything significant. The sun came up over the Mouth the way it comes up over the Mouth about three hundred and sixty times a year, and somewhere eleven miles east a hundred and forty men were waking up in a cold field to find there was still no bread.

She sat on the stilt-shed steps for four minutes with her wet hands on her knees and let herself have those, and then she got in the boat.

Afterwards, when people asked her about that week — and eventually people did ask her, because that is what happens to you once a story gets loose — she would talk about the bridge, or the bill, or the pier, and she would be generous and funny about all of it.

She never once mentioned the Lost Isle.

*
**

By the time she was back on the Shoals the city had stopped working, and it had stopped working *politely*, which was the part that made it beautiful.

There was a Dragon Knight on the Fishmarket steps trying to hire a boatman to take him to High Isle, and not one of the six men sitting

there was looking up. There was no ice. There was no bread off the Fishmarket. There was no boat at the Vanttt landing and no boy to run a message and no rope to be had when a man wanted rope, and everybody was very, very sorry about all of it.

Nobody was rude. That was the instruction and that was the genius of it. You cannot put a city to the sword for being apologetic.

Four Knights rowed themselves to High Isle that morning in a hired boat with nobody to hire, and went round and round in the Lullwater for twenty minutes while the fish market watched in reverent silence, and one of them lost his pole and had to be given it back by a nine-year-old.

Nobody laughed out loud.

The entire city laughed for the rest of the year.

*

**

Temple Isle has no bridge to it, so half of Purewater was afloat by first light, gunwale to gunwale in a great slow ring off the steps with families standing up in the boats and children on shoulders and a man working the outside of the ring selling something hot out of a tub, which is the most Purewater fact available about any religious occasion.

The Sacred Confluence comes down off the temple in shallow terraces to a pool at the waterline and a broad stair of wet green stone, and by the Order's long form every combatant and the head of their house goes down to be blessed before the sand. Nerissa's novices worked the running order with white rods and not one atom of deference to anybody, which Kag enjoyed enormously.

The di Teufels were called near the end.

The Baron came down the green stone with his shirt off and there it was: a flat black chain, close to the throat, and something small on it under the hollow of his collarbone. Nine weeks in this city and nobody had ever seen him without it, and here he was in front of four thousand

people stripped to the waist on somebody else's ground, because the Lady's water does not care whose army you brought.

And behind him, bare-headed in daylight for the second time in his life, came a boy of seventeen who was too thin for the body he was in and who walked like somebody being walked.

The stair packed solid behind them with forty people trying to see.

A body-length off the Baron's left shoulder, going down the steps with his head turned the other way, was a nineteen-year-old thief called Nus who had the best hands on that water and had been circling Kag for two days looking for somebody to tell him he was the man for it.

*
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The priestess put the Baron under with a hand flat on the back of his neck and held him there a good deal longer than that man had been held anywhere in nine weeks, and Kag, sitting in a hired skiff twenty-five metres out, revised her opinion of the Order considerably upwards.

He came up streaming. Somebody put a cloth in his hands. The whole stair closed in behind to get the boy in next, and for about four seconds there was nothing on those steps but wet backs and elbows.

Nus went past him on the step above, close as a man passing in a corridor, and his hand went across the Baron's throat and off again, and he kept walking.

Nothing came away in his fist.

And nothing happened, either — the Baron did not turn round, because he had a cloth over his face and his son's killer was twenty-five metres away in a hired boat and a thief had just had his fingers on the thing at his throat, and he was drying his eyes.

Kag was the only person on that water who saw it, and she was the only person who saw *why*.

There was no clasp on it.

It was a closed ring, worn short and tight at the collarbone, and it had been on that man since before any of this started, and it did not lift and it did not come over a head. It came off with a cut, off the living man, or it did not come off at all.

Nus got to the top of the stair and turned and found her across the water, and stood there, waiting to be told.

And Kag shook her head. Once. That was the entire conversation.

Something went out of his shoulders, and he turned and went up between the temple wall and the crowd and did not look back.

*

**

She would find out weeks later what that had cost — or rather what it had *not* cost, which is a harder thing to be told about and impossible to feel properly.

Below the Fishmarket there are four thousand people living on plank walkways and boat-houses on stilts and six rope bridges, in the one part of Purewater that armed men have never gone into, because horses are useless there and the locals know every roof. If that chain had come off the Baron's neck on the Temple steps in front of the whole city, they would have gone in at dawn with hooks, and they would have cut the bridges first, because cutting six rope bridges turns a neighbourhood into forty islands of frightened people who cannot reach each other.

None of that happened.

It did not happen because a debt collector in a hired skiff shook her head at a boy across twenty-five metres of water, and not one of those four thousand people will ever know it, and that is simply how it works.

The boy came up out of the Lady's water and stood there dripping and did not wipe his face and did not blink.

The priestess who had put him under took her hand off him early — a count or two early, where every other man on that stair had got the full measure and a bit over for being important — and stepped back off

the bottom step with her skirts dragging and looked up the terraces at the High Priestess, and waited to be told something.

Nerissa did not tell her anything. Nerissa said the words over the boy from where she stood, in the same voice she had used all morning, and the white rods moved the next house down.

The Baron already had his shirt on.

Kag watched the pair of them go up the green stone and thought about a chain with no clasp, and how you would get at a thing like that, and where a man like that ever stands still.

She had no idea at all.

She had, however, just watched four thousand people on a religious holiday, and every last one of them had been looking at somebody else.

CHAPTER 13 — HE BEGS



GARDWEN HAD BEEN IN THE TREES, and she had watched them take him, and she had not come out — and everything she had done in the ten years since had been an argument with that one night, conducted alone, in the open, in weather, against a version of herself who was nine years old and would not accept any of it.

She had buried the steading. She had spoken the rites over people she had known her whole life and could no longer recognise. She had walked out of the deep woods at seventeen with a wolf who chose her and a conviction that everybody she met treated as a kindness they were not going to argue with, which was that her brother had survived, and was alive, and was somewhere, and was seven.

And on Wednesday afternoon, on a competitors' ground in a city built on water, a boy had been walked out in harness and the helm had come off for four seconds and she had been right for ten years and it had not helped at all.

That was the part nobody warns you about either. Being right is not the same as getting him back. Being right is just the moment you stop having anywhere to put the hope.

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So on Thursday evening she went down to the seaward rocks at High Isle and took her boots off.

She set them side by side on a flat stone above the tideline and tied them together at the tops, the way you do at a bathing place, and she remembered doing it and thought it was a strange thing to be tidy about, and did it anyway.

Ruhi came to the edge of the water and stopped, because Ruhi had spent four years going everywhere and would not go there.

“Stay,” Gardwen said, which she had never once had to say to that animal.

The wolf sat down on the high rock with her forelegs braced and did not make a sound, and Gardwen went into the October sea off the north-east of a city with a hundred and forty tents of enemy eleven miles east of her, entirely alone, on the grounds that her brother was in a ship and nobody was doing anything about it.

She was, in her own considered opinion, a fucking idiot. She had thought so at the time. She went anyway.

*
**

The cold takes your breath in a fist and then it takes your hands, in that order, and after about an hour it starts taking your judgement, which is the dangerous one.

She got to the stern chains and got her forearms over them and hung there in the dark under the counter of the Baron’s ship with the water going up and down her by a foot and a half, and she found the one piece of good fortune available that night, which was that the hull was *warm* down there, because the galley flue ran down the stern and the planking above the waterline had heat in it.

Warm planking carries sound.

And so a druid of the deep woods, hanging off a mooring chain in the sea with her lips going blue, put her ear against two inches of oak and listened to the most important quarter of an hour in the entire history of her family.

*
**

He came down at about nine.

She knew it was him because the whole ship changed — the small noises of twenty people stopped for a moment, the way a house stops when the master comes in — and then there were boots on a companionway and a door, and then a voice.

And here is the thing she was not remotely prepared for.

He was *kind*.

That is the word. She used it twice when she finally told it and she never afterwards found a better one and she hated it every time. Baron Hanzo di Teufel went down below the waterline of his own ship to a boy he had stolen at seven years old, and he sat with him for a quarter of an hour, and he talked to him low and steady and gently, the way you settle a horse that has been frightened by weather. There was no cruelty in it anywhere. It would have been so much easier if there had been.

He said the boy's name. He said *Cailan*, out loud, more than once, which meant that somewhere in ten years he had bothered to keep it, which meant he had chosen to.

And then he said the other name, three times, and Gardwen got it wrong because of the water and the oak, but what she heard was *Thuban*.

And something answered him.

Not a seventeen-year-old. It was a grown man's voice and it came out of that chest wrong, the way a note comes out of a cracked bell, and what it was doing — underneath the Baron's voice, continuously, the entire quarter of an hour, never once stopping —

— was asking to be let go.

Not screaming. Not threatening. Asking. Over and over, patiently, the way a man in a cell asks for water, and the Baron talked gently across the top of it and did not acknowledge it even once, because he had been doing this every night for ten years and had long ago stopped hearing it.

Gardwen hung on a chain in the black sea and listened to her brother's body beg.

*
**

She lost the last of it, which was the part about what would be wanted tomorrow, because the tide came up and she could not get her ear back onto the planking and her hands had stopped being hands.

That was when she slipped, and the chain rang.

Lanterns came out along the pier, four of them and then six. Men with boat-hooks going down into the water by the mooring chains. A light held over the side and walked the whole length of the hull, twice, and a voice giving orders that never once rose.

She went under the counter and stayed there for two hours in the cold with hooks going past her, holding on with her forearms because her fingers had finished, and thinking about absolutely nothing at all except the next breath, which is what the sea does to you and is, on balance, a mercy.

*
**

And after he had gone, when it was just the water and the ship's timbers and the ordinary noise of a vessel at night — she heard the other thing.

Somebody in there was crying.

A boy. Not the other one. A boy, seventeen, on his own, in the dark, below a waterline, after his father had gone up the companionway and shut the door.

He was in there the whole time.

He had been in there the whole time, for ten years, listening to all of it.

*
**

She did not remember the swim back and she did not remember the rocks.

What she remembered afterwards, and what she never told anybody except once, badly, on a wash-room floor, was the wolf coming down off the high rock in four jumps and going into the shallows to her chest and getting a mouthful of her shirt, and an enormous grey shape coming off the stones into the water to her thighs to take the rest of her weight, and somebody saying *I've got her*.

And then Magda — sixty-odd years old and a head and a half shorter than any of them — carrying her up Constantine's water steps herself, and refusing, with a flat and appalling calm, to give her to anybody else on the way.

They got her onto the wash-room floor with every blanket in the house and the firebox roaring, and Constantine did it slowly, because she had seen what hot does to men pulled out of the Mouth in February.

Magda sat on the boards with Gardwen's head on her thigh and rubbed her hands between her own, hard, the way you bring a lamb round, and said the entire time, in a completely level voice, that she was a bloody fool, and that she would be up in an hour, and that this was nothing.

She did not believe one word of it. Gardwen could hear that she did not.

It was better than an hour before the shaking started, which Constantine said was the good sign.

*
**

She got hold of the half-orc's collar with a hand that could not grip and said it straight into her face, because it had to come out first, before the cold, before the names, before any of the rest of it.

"He *begs*."

A beat.

And then, when her mouth would work again, the rest — the quarter of an hour, the kindness, the voice out of the cracked bell, the boy crying on his own in the dark afterwards.

“He calls him by his name,” she said. “Cailan. He says it every night.”

She lay on her back on a wash-room floor with a wolf across her feet and her eyes shut and made the one deduction that none of the rest of them had got to, and made it out loud, slowly, because her mouth was still bad.

“If they take him — wherever he goes, the chain goes on him. In a cell, or a box in some clerk’s cupboard, or on a body. And there’s nobody holding the other end. And whatever that is in my brother has been asking to be let out for ten years.”

The firebox ticked.

“So it comes off first,” Gardwen said. “Then you can do whatever you like with him.”

CHAPTER 14 — A MAN WHO CANNOT BUY A FISH



BLAU HAD NOT BEEN FRIGHTENED OF ANYTHING SINCE HE WAS NINETEEN YEARS OLD, and he understood perfectly well that this was not courage — courage is a thing that costs you something every time you spend it — but an absence, burned out of him along with most of the left side of his face in a farmhouse that no longer existed, in a war that nobody in Purewater had ever heard of, on an afternoon he had stopped being able to remember the smell of about a decade ago and which he did not miss.

What the fire had actually taken was his belief that noise achieves anything.

Everybody else he had ever worked with shouted. Shouting was the whole industry. Shouting at the men, shouting at the locals, shouting at the boy who fetched the horses, shouting — God help them all — at Hanzo di Teufel, which was a thing four separate men had tried in nineteen years and which had worked precisely never. Blau did not shout and had not shouted since he was nineteen, and the effect of that on a household was extraordinary and had been quietly making him indispensable for two decades.

He was not loyal to the Baron. He wanted to be clear about that with himself, periodically, the way you check a knot.

He was loyal to finishing things.

*
**

On the Friday morning he came ashore at half seven and discovered, standing on the Fishmarket bridge with a purse in his hand, that he could not buy a fish.

It was not a scene. That was the thing about it and he admired it, distantly, the way he admired most competent work. The woman behind the trestle weighed whiting for a man on his left, and finished, and started on somebody else, and the queue simply rearranged itself around him the way water goes round a post. Nobody refused him. Nobody looked at him. Two porters had stopped to watch and were pretending they had not.

He had been standing there ten minutes.

Behind him his two Knights were grey in the face, and one of them had his hand on the rail, and neither of them had eaten since Wednesday.

Blau ran the situation the way he ran everything, which was as a list of facts with no adjectives attached.

The young master had walked off his father's ship on Tuesday night after a child handed him a bundle at a landing, and had not come back. That was four days. The Baron did not yet know, because Blau had not told him, because telling him was what made a mess expensive, and because the version currently circulating in the taverns — that Lord Santo had ridden out of Purewater at midnight with a Pearl girl in his brother's coat, witnessed from two bridges by about sixty people who had no reason on earth to lie about it — was the most useful thing that had happened to Blau in a fortnight and he had no intention of disturbing it.

He was, he acknowledged, entirely prepared to believe it himself. The boy had done less plausible things.

What he was not prepared to do was leave a knife lying in a canal.

*
**

He had hired eight of them off that bridge on Wednesday, out of his own purse, and told each one they were the only one, which was a routine precaution and which had held for about four hours on the grounds that you cannot hire eight people off one bridge and have nobody notice. He knew that when he did it. The eight were not for information. The eight were to find out who came and bought them, and by Thursday evening he knew exactly who had — because six of his slates had started coming back with the same flavour of nothing on them, which is the signature of a professional, and there was only one of those in this city.

Crowbill. Fine. That told him what he needed, which was the shape of the thing he was standing in.

The dredgers were the part he was actually pleased with.

Ten sovereigns a boat, out of his own purse again, to every dredger on that water — *any canal, any depth, no questions asked or answered* — and a drawing of the blade done himself with a fine nib, because he had held that knife on four separate occasions and could draw it with his eyes shut. The Dredgers were Guild to nobody and answered to nobody, which meant Crowbill had never been able to buy them in thirty years and neither had anybody else, and Blau had walked in and bought all of them in a morning with money.

He did not care about the body. A body in this city is a problem for the person who put it there. He cared about eleven inches of barbed iron with his employer's *sigil on the pommel*, sitting in the mud of a canal or, far worse, in somebody's kitchen drawer — because a body is an accusation against one man and that knife is an accusation against a house.

Nineteen years of cleaning up after the young master, and the boy had managed, on his way out of the world, to leave behind the only object that could hang the family.

Blau had a certain professional respect for that. It was the most effective thing Santo di Teufel had ever done.

**

The half-orc came over the bridge toward him at about twenty to eight and he watched her come the whole way.

Everybody else on that bridge had spent the morning being extremely apologetic at him. This one walked straight up, which meant she wanted something, which meant she was the first useful thing on this island in four days.

“I need to hire somebody in Purewater,” he said. “Nobody in Purewater will take my money.”

He turned his hands over, empty, which he did deliberately, because he had learned a long time ago that an empty hand is worth more than a threat to anybody who is any good.

“You’re the first person in two days who’s walked toward me. What will it cost?”

She told him she was Crowbill’s and that he was therefore talking to Crowbill, and Blau said *good* and meant it, because a man with a price is a considerably simpler proposition than a man with feelings.

And then he laid it out and watched her take it without a flicker.

Six boats. Tonight, after the closing, off High Isle’s seaward pier on the ebb, out through the Mouth and east along the coast — not up the Anminster road, which he did not explain and which she did not ask about. Twenty-two people and their gear. Cash on the stones before anything went aboard.

“And there’s one more thing that comes with us,” he said. “It goes in the bottom of a boat, it doesn’t get opened, and nobody puts a hand on it but me.”

In eleven minutes of talking on that bridge he did not once say *my lord*, or *the Baron*, or *di Teufel*, and he did not name anybody he worked for at all.

He noticed himself not doing it, afterwards, on the water, and turned it over for a while, and let it go.

**

Here is what nobody in Purewater knew, and what Blau had told exactly no one in nineteen years, because telling is how people lose things.

He had watched Hanzo di Teufel seat a spirit in a living body eleven times.

He had held the lamp. He had carried the case. He had put the boy back in the hold afterwards and washed the floor, and he had stood four feet away for every step of it because somebody always has to be holding something, and he had no ear for the working whatsoever and had known that about himself since he was twenty. He could not have said one word of it if you put a knife in him.

But he knew the *order*. He knew what the boy looked like on the second morning as against the third. He knew the step that had to be done every single day at first light or the edges of the seat worked loose, because he had watched it done at first light every single day for ten years, in ports and in fields and once in the back of a moving wagon.

And the man who had that knowledge in his hands did not need to be a mage.

He needed a vessel, and a chain, and a boat.

**

The bill came back at noon and it was the single most impressive thing Blau encountered in the whole of that miserable week, and he did not realise until much later that it had been built specifically to interrogate him.

It was itemised. Hulls, at forty-five the boat, because a boat that goes out past the bar at night with armed strangers in it may not come back and is therefore sold and not hired — which was correct, and which he had never seen a boatman have the nerve to write down. Polers at eight *the man*. Passage at four *the head*. One item carried in the bilge, not opened, at the contractor's risk, priced on its own,

because whoever wrote it had understood inside about four seconds that it was the only line he could not do without.

Six hundred, and he would have paid nine.

And the passage line said, in words, in a boy's flat recitation on a landing step: *twenty-two heads at four the head, every head the same rate, servant, soldier, and his lordship.*

Blau read that back three times in his head and felt something he had not felt in a very long time, which was mild, genuine amusement.

Four shillings. They had priced Hanzo di Teufel, Baron of Teufel, at four shillings and put him on a list between a cook and a sergeant.

He could have let it stand. He thought about letting it stand for perhaps two seconds, and then he corrected it, because he was a professional and a professional does not go out on a night tide with a manifest that says twenty-two when it says twenty-one, and because in nineteen years he had never once knowingly left a wrong number on a piece of paper.

"Agreed, the whole of it, six hundred, cash on the stones at dusk," he told the boy in the green cap. "And tell them one line's wrong. Twenty-one heads, not twenty-two." A beat. "And the item goes in the boat first, not last."

The boy said it back twice, which was good practice, and ran off north with it.

Blau watched him go and then went and stood at the end of the Guild landing for a while, looking at the water, at a city that would not sell him bread, which he was leaving tonight with everything that mattered in the bottom of a boat.

He had not eaten in two days himself. He had not really noticed.

It did not once occur to him — and this was the only genuine mistake he made all week, and it was the same mistake every single person in that city made about her — that the woman who had written him that bill had written it in order to *ask him a question*, and that he had just answered it.

CHAPTER 15 — AN ITEMISED BILL



KAG FOUND THE MAN WHO WAS FOLLOWING HER IN ABOUT A MINUTE, which was not a triumph of tradecraft on her part but an act of mercy on his, because he was two boats back and he had plainly never done this before in his life and he was trying extremely hard.

He changed ferries when she changed ferries. He got out at the Fishmarket steps and then could not think of a single reason to be at the Fishmarket steps, so he bought a fish he did not want and stood on the stones holding it.

It was Dess. Rope and cordage, third pitch along. Eleven shillings short on Monday because four of them had walked off with sixty feet of his best line.

She came up behind him and cleared her throat, and Dess went about four inches straight up and the fish went in the water.

“That was my dinner,” he said, and then shut his eyes.

It took ten seconds after that. A shilling a day and sixpence for anything written down, and he was to say where she went and who she spoke to and whether she went on the water at night, and he gave the whole thing up so fast and so completely that it was obvious he had been sick about it since noon.

“They gave me a slate,” Dess said, and produced a slate. There was nothing on it. “I didn’t know how to spell half orc.”

So she took the slate off him and wrote it out in a hand better than his and worse than a clerk’s.

Went Pearl about 3. Sylph’s Embrace. Big argument with the woman Constantine out in the street, heard by all. Left angry. Fishmarket. Ate. Did not go on the water.

Not one word of it was a lie. That was the trick of it, and it was a trick she had off nine years of debt collection: the very best lie you will ever tell is a true statement with the interesting bit taken out.

“There’s eight of us,” Dess said, when he had got his coat closed over it, and he said it without being asked, because he was talking now and could not stop. “He hired eight off this bridge out of his own purse and told every one of us we were the only one.”

“Where do the slates go?”

“Six o’clock. Under the third arch of the Gate of Triumph bridge, on the water. He doesn’t come himself.” Dess rubbed his thumb on the frame. “There’s a woman in a boat.”

*
**

The woman in the boat was fifty-odd and built like the winch she was sitting next to, with cloth wound round her head and her boots off in October and a pipe that did not come out of her mouth for conversation, and she saw Kag coming a very long time before Kag arrived, because she had spent thirty-five years looking at water for a living and knowing what was in it that should not be.

She hauled the bucket up off its line and set it inside the gunwale, which meant no slates tonight, and then let Kag come the rest of the way in her own time.

“Say it out loud or clear off.”

Kag laughed at herself, which turned out to be the correct opening, and asked whether the woman knew her.

“Everybody on this water knows you. You’re Crowbill’s counting — big grey one, does the bridges on the Shoals, reads a book.” The pipe went round to the other side. “And you’re the one that stood on the Fishmarket bridge on Monday and told four of the Baron’s men to their faces they were thieves, in front of the whole market, and then walked up the steps.”

A beat.

“My sister’s boy was on that bridge. He’s told it nine hundred times and it gets better every time.”

Her name was Ossa Kyne and she did not do favours — she said so, plainly, twice, because favours make you part of a thing and she had spent thirty-five years not being part of things. Then she answered the question anyway, for her sister’s boy, which is how almost everything in that city actually gets done.

“He’s not looking for a man. Not once did he say a man, nor a body, nor a size, nor a night.” She came up with a folded square of paper out of an oilcloth. “He’s looking for a knife.”

It was a drawing. A single blade near enough to life size, done in ink with a fine nib, barbed along the back edge, and a mark near the hilt rendered with a great deal more care than the rest of it — every line of it separate, by somebody who knew that mark extremely well.

Underneath, in a small tidy hand: *any canal, any depth. Ten sovereigns. No questions asked or answered.*

“He gave one of those to every dredger on the water,” Ossa said.

Ten sovereigns was more than that woman made in a season, and there were eleven dredgers on that water, and the man had paid it out of his own purse in a city that would not sell him bread.

He is not frightened of a body, Kag thought, sitting in a skiff under a bridge in the dark with a drawing in her hand. *He is frightened of a knife.*

And the knife had never left the room.

That was the whole of it, and she had not done it out of cleverness. She had done it on Tuesday night because a debt collector knows that a thing in your hand is yours and a thing on a floor with a witness in the doorway belongs to the truth. She had turned it a quarter-turn with the back of her own knife and taken a rubbing and left it lying.

So on Friday evening, four nights on, it was still against the skirting on the third floor at the Sylph's Embrace — in a house the grey man had walked through that same afternoon, asking politely after a thirteen-year-old girl — with the blood gone from black and tacky to black and dry.

She took it out in a doubled linen off Constantine's press, tied at both ends with kitchen twine, laid in with the flat of her own blade so that no finger of hers went near the hooks.

And in the other hand she had the thing that was worth more, which was a house ledger written on the night, standing up, in a clear round hand, by the woman who owned the room.

*
**

Temerach Nebulo was at the back corner table of the Moist Oyster with her back to the wall and a mail coat across her knees, going along the rings one at a time with a small tool, while down at the fire end Thorne told forty people about an elf who had put four arrows in the middle at two hundred paces that morning. It had been three arrows that morning. By Thursday it would be six and a gale.

The elf was ignoring all of it, which Kag liked her for immediately.

She put the tool down flat on the table, which from a woman who had not stopped for the whole of Thorne's performance was a considerable quantity of attention.

"Say the girl's name or don't, I don't need it yet. The scroll. How much of it is there, is it burnt, and how do you know the hand is his?"

Kag told her. Three pieces. Out of a grate. A grown man's fast practised hand, and the same figure drawn twice that was cut into the pommel.

"Who saw it come out of the grate besides you?"

Constantine. And it was in her house ledger, written that night, standing up, and she had offered to countersign it in daylight.

"And the mark on the knife?"

Orsk & Daughter, in the Forge Quarter. Hild's book, chained to the bench, four generations of it. Cut to a stranger's drawing on the fourth of June — four months before the column ever came down the Anminster road.

Something happened behind the elf's face and was gone before it could be named.

"Where is the knife now?"

"We've got it. You can have the lot of it if you ask."

And Temerach Nebulo, who had spent four years trying to get Hanzo di Teufel called to answer and had never once dared open her mouth about it, did not say yes.

"A Purewater thief walks into a tavern," she said, "and offers a King's officer the one thing she has wanted for four years, for nothing at all." Her eyes came up. "What do you want?"

"I want the fucker gone. He's a scourge on this city and I resent his men strutting about like they own the place."

The elf nodded once, because it matched what three separate people had told her about this woman before supper.

"Good. That I can work with. A man who wants paying I have to think about."

*
**

At seven the next morning, in a shed on the water at the end of the founders' lane, two women who kept books established inside about

ninety seconds that they liked each other, and then went at it like a stocktake.

Constantine described a clerk's hand. Hild described a callus. Constantine said *ink on the middle finger, not the first*, and Hild said *that's a man who's held a pen fifty years*, and Temerach said almost nothing and wrote almost everything down in a small tight hand on paper she had brought with her.

Kag stood at the back by the quench tub with her arms folded and let the honest people work, and she was, on the whole, more uncomfortable there than she had been on the Lost Isle, and she did not examine that.

Then Hild put both hands flat on the bench and said no.

"I'll not swear a Baron bought it. A Baron didn't buy it. A Purewater man of about fifty-five bought it, with ink on his middle finger and the buttons cut off his coat so there'd be nothing on him to know him by, and he stood where you're stood and he was frightened the whole time he was in this shed."

She looked up.

"My great-grandfather started that book. Nobody has ever put a thing in it that wasn't so."

And Temerach Nebulo, who had not moved from the door in half an hour, let out a breath that was almost certainly relief.

"Good," she said. "That's the only kind of witness worth having."

A beat.

"Would you know him again?"

*
**

Hild went to the back of the shed and was gone a while, and there was the sound of a chest, and she came back with a second book — smaller, unchained, the instrument book — and turned the pages with her thumb.

"I've made for him. Twice. A pair of calipers and a brass rule with a Guild stamp on the tang."

She turned it round.

"I never knew him in the shed in June because he wasn't in his coat. That's why he cut the buttons off." She tapped the page. "It's not the buttons. It's the *indigo*."

There was a name on the line, and a Guild, and the date was two years old, and the hand was Hild's own.

Ivo Calder. Tide Master, Watercrafters Guild. Assessor by appointment to the city of Purewater.

"That," said Constantine, to nobody in particular, "is the man who signed off the Lady's fouling as a false reading in the spring."

The bellows went next door and the whole shed breathed in, and four women stood round a bench in the Forge Quarter and understood, all at the same moment and none of them saying it, that whatever had come down the Anminster road nine weeks ago had been *invited*.

Kag went out into the founders' lane at eight in the morning with sixty workshops around her and a question she had no idea how to answer, which was how you get a closed ring of black iron off a living man's throat in a room full of people in about two seconds.

She was still standing there when Pell came round the corner at a dead run.

CHAPTER 16 — CROWBILL'S TOWN



KAG STOOD ON HIGH ISLE'S SEAWARD PIER AT DUSK IN THE OPEN with a lamp beside her and six hundred sovereigns about to be counted into her hands, and the single strangest thing about the most dangerous evening of her life was that she was not hiding from anybody, because she was the contractor, and the contractor stands where the contractor stands.

Hild had put a tool in her hand at six o'clock, black, no shine on it anywhere, made that afternoon at speed and tempered properly and fitted to her own palm off a string measurement taken across the bench. A little hooked thing with a hardened wheel and a flat tongue in front of the wheel. Four hundred years old, that idea, and it exists because old women's fingers swell and the ring has to come off and you cannot have it come off with the finger.

The tongue goes under, between the ring and the flesh, and the wheel rides on the tongue, and it cuts metal and it cannot cut meat, because there's steel in the way.

And: Three turns. Not two, and not until it feels right, because it never feels right, and men have stood there sawing at a thing for a minute and a half and been killed doing it.

Count them out loud if you have to, the dwarf had said.

*
**

They came off the ship at twenty to seven and they came off *well*, which told Kag a great deal about who had actually been running that vessel for two days. No shouting. Bundles first, then people, in ones and twos, down the plank and along the stones in a line that did not bunch.

Twenty-one of them. She counted, because of course she counted.

Blau came down third and walked straight to her and counted six hundred into her hands in coin, on the stones, in front of his own people, and took his time over it, and did not ask her to count it after.

“Boats look right,” he said.

The last thing off that ship came up out of the hold on ropes: a chest, near seven feet, rope beackets at both ends, and it took four of them and they struggled with it and it was very much heavier than a chest that size. It did not shift inside. It made no sound at all. The underside was wet and steaming faintly in the cold, because it had spent its whole life below a waterline.

Blau put both hands on it going down the plank and did not take them off until it was in the bilge of the second boat.

Kag’s boat. Kag’s man on the rope.

And a skiff went off the end of that pier like a man carrying a message about boats, and four minutes later a girl with a tray crossed a slope in the dark and offered a cup at a woman’s elbow, and Mariarta of the Promise of Heaven put a copy of Kag’s own handwriting into the hand of a mercenary captain who had been standing at the back of his own men for four days running, waiting to be told what was happening.

*
**

Seven o’clock came and went, and five boats were loaded, and the sixth took the last four and their gear, and there was nothing on the path up from the terraces. Nothing at all. No lamp, no runner, no sound.

Blau came down the stones to the head of the line and put his hand on the second boat’s gunwale, above the chest.

"Right," he said, not loudly, to the whole pier. "Cast off."

And Kag, who could not think of anything clever, put her head up and walked back along the stones with her hand raised, the way a person does when they have heard something over water.

"You've been paid," Blau said. He did not move off the gunwale. "You want me on these stones another ten minutes and I've no idea why, and I'd rather not find out on a falling tide."

He straightened up. "Cast off. All of them."

And then everybody else on that pier heard it too.

Boots on stone, up on the path from the terraces. One man, running, and running the way a man runs when he is not thinking about the ground at all. Then a second set and a third, a long way behind and losing.

Baron Hanzo di Teufel came off the path onto the pier at a dead run in the clothes he had stood in front of a Prince in an hour before. No harness, no sword, no household, one shoe gone somewhere on that hill, and he was fifty-one years old and he had run the better part of a mile.

He stopped dead at the head of the line.

He was not looking at Blau at all.

He was looking at the second boat, and the wet black chest lying in the bottom of it, with two of Crowbill's men either side holding water with their poles.

*
**

"Take it out of the boat." His voice was wrecked from the running and it was not loud. "Put it back aboard, and I will not have heard any of this."

"No, my lord."

"..."

"You'd never have got him home." Blau had not moved. There was no relish in it and no apology either. "You've been telling him he was going home for ten years and the boy believes it, and you don't."

Twenty-one people sat in five boats and did not move and did not say one word, because they were his household and he was still their Baron, and not one of them had worked out which way this went.

Blau got out of the boat and put himself on the stones between the two of them and put a hand flat on the Baron's chest, and Hanzo walked into it and stopped.

And then he looked past Blau's shoulder at the chest, and said a name.

Not loudly. Low and steady and kind — the exact voice Gardwen had described through two inches of oak, the voice you use on a horse — and it carried the whole length of that pier because every other sound on it had stopped.

"Thuban."

The chest moved.

Once. A single heavy shift, like something settling, and the boat under it dipped and came back and the water slapped along the stones, and both of Crowbill's men in that boat were suddenly holding their poles very badly indeed.

He said it again, and added three words in a language that put the hair up on Kag's arms.

And something inside seven feet of wet oak took hold of the lid from underneath.

*
**

She went round the outside of the lamps with the tool already in her left hand and the thumb loop on, and the Baron of Teufel saw her coming and dismissed her.

His eyes came off the chest and went over her once — the size, the leather, the club, the lamp behind — and went straight back to the boat.

A dock half-orc, moving on a dock. He did not have room in his head that night for whatever she was, and he never had had, and neither had anybody else in thirty years, and it was the first time in her entire life that it had been worth anything at all.

Three steps and she was on him.

Her left hand went inside the open collar and her fingers got under the ring — and there was the slack, half a finger's worth, where nine weeks of this city had taken the flesh off him — and she hauled it up off the skin and held it there, and he came back against her like a sack, because he was fifty-one and he had just run a mile.

The tongue went under. Steel between iron and throat, exactly as the dwarf had said.

One. Two. Three.

And the ring did not part.

What it did was bite. A bright notch cut in the black iron the width of a fingernail, silver in the lamplight, and the wheel sitting in the bottom of it, and the ring still a ring.

Down the pier Blau turned round. In the boat the lid of the chest lifted three inches and stopped, held from underneath.

And the Baron, hanging off her left hand with his windpipe half shut, got both arms up in front of him and began to say something that was not in any language ever spoken on that water.

She tried to get her head into the back of his skull and could not do it past her own arm.

He finished the words.

*
**

Everything stopped except her eyes and her ears.

Her left fist was inside his collar with the ring hauled up off his throat and her right thumb was through the loop with the wheel in its notch, and that is where they stayed, and they were not going

anywhere, and neither was she. The shout she had been going to make got as far as the back of her teeth and stopped there.

Out on the black water somebody said one quiet word and nothing whatsoever happened to him. He did not even turn his head towards it.

And then four crossbows went off out of the dark at about nine feet.

They fired because Crowbill had given four men one instruction on Thursday afternoon — *not unless a man starts casting, and then until he stops* — and because Crowbill's people do exactly what Crowbill said, which is the entire reason he had lasted thirty years and the entire reason it had been no use to her ten seconds earlier.

Two of them found him. Both of them found the same place.

Hanzo di Teufel stopped being a man in the middle of a word. He went down instantly and completely and straight down, and he did not fall away from her, because her fist was shut in his collar, so he hung there off her frozen arm with his whole weight on her knuckles and his chin on her wrist.

The ring was six inches under her eyes with one bright notch in it.

She could not turn the wheel. She could not let go. She could not say a word.

*
**

The skiff came in out of the dark on the seaward side without a lamp, close enough that the ship's two lights picked it up, and a figure in a plain coat stood up in the stern in front of twenty-one people, Blau, six boat crews and whatever was standing in the second boat.

Three words, and a hand cut sideways through the air.

Hesper had spent an entire career being nobody, on the settled understanding that a described intelligencer is a dead one, and they broke that in front of twenty-six witnesses for a half-orc they had known for four days, and then sat back down and let the boat back away as though nothing had occurred.

It went out of Kag all at once and it was horrible, and she and the Baron of Teufel went down onto the wet stone together in a heap with her fist still shut in his collar.

She got a knee under her.

Three turns.

On the third the wheel went through and the notch became a gap, and the ring *sprang* — sprang, like a thing that had been under tension for ten years — and the two cut ends jumped apart under her thumb and it came off the dead man's throat into her left hand.

There was a locket on it the size of a thumbnail.

It was warm. It was very much warmer than anything else on that pier.

*
**

Above her, the thing standing in the wet shift made a sound.

Not a cry and not a word. Something going out of a chest, all of it, the way a man breathes out at the end of a very long day, and it went on a great deal longer than any lungs that size had any business holding.

And then the grown man's voice said one thing, and it was not to the pier and not to the dead man and not to anybody who had ever been afraid of it.

"Hold him. He'll not know how to stand."

Ten years a prisoner in somebody else's bones, begging every night to be let out, and the last thing Thuban Eta did on his way out of the world was worry about the boy.

The boy folded.

Kag got an arm up and took about half of him and he came down across her knees on the stones, seventeen years old and eight stone of nothing, and his eyes were open and moving and he was looking

at the lamps and the boats and the sky like somebody who had never seen any of it in his life.

He made a noise. It was a boy's noise.

And behind her on the stones Gardwen came apart entirely, and Magda let her go, and the woman from the woods got there on her hands and knees.

*

**

Nobody in those boats drew a blade. There was not one sword out on that water.

Twenty-one people sat in five boats with everything they owned under the thwarts on a running ebb, forty feet off a pier, and the poles were in Purewater hands, and not a single one of them could crew anything. Two were standing. One of those was being sick over the side. An older man in the third boat had taken his hat off, and nobody had told him to.

They were waiting to be told what they were now, because the man who told them that was face down under Kag's knee with the back of his head opened up, and the man who was going to tell them next was standing eleven feet away and had not said anything for a minute and a half.

Blau came down the stones. He was not looking at his Baron and he was not looking at the boy.

"That," he said, "is mine."

"Since when, you cold-faced bastard?"

"Since he was forty-four and I was nineteen." He put his hands behind his back, which was somehow worse than reaching for something. "I have watched that man seat a spirit in a living body eleven times, and I have carried that locket in my own hand while he slept. There is not another person on this earth who knows what you are holding."

A beat.

“And you are going to need to know, tonight, because that boy is not finished.”

*
**

He sold it for a boat, a man on the pole, and the sea, and he did not ask for the locket, and he did not haggle, and he put his own hands out to be tied.

What he gave for nothing, because they would have found it out by Thursday and Thursday would have been too late, was this: a seat ten years deep is a hole cut in a person, and it does not close because the tenant has walked out of it, and there is a step that was done at first light every single morning for ten years to keep the edges of it from working loose.

Nobody was going to do that on Wednesday.

Four mornings. That was the clock now.

*
**

They brought the Baron up wrapped in a boat sail and he weighed almost nothing at all, which was the last thing Kag ever learned about Hanzo di Teufel.

Crowbill came down to the water himself, which he had not done once all week. He looked at the sail, and at the man tied in the bottom of the boat, and at the black ring lying open in her palm with the small warm thing on it, and at a seventeen-year-old asleep against his sister under Magda's coat.

“Right,” he said.

The body went into the ice-house on the stone under sacking, because the run goes out over the bar at four every morning of the year, and both di Teufels would leave Purewater the same way inside two days and neither of them would ever be found.

He took the six hundred off her and counted it, and then put two of every five back into her hands without a word, which he had never once done in front of witnesses.

And at the top of the steps he stopped.

“They heard you on that pier. Twenty-six people, and five of them were mine, and mine will tell it.”

This is Crowbill’s fucking town. She had said it out loud, in the dark, standing over a dead nobleman with a cut ring in her fist, to twenty-one people in boats who had nowhere on earth to go.

He almost smiled.

“Go and sleep, Kag. You’ll be hearing that one back off strangers by Friday.”

She went home over four bridges in the dark and did not meet one person who knew her name, and every single one of them stepped out of her way, the way they always had.

They had been doing it for thirty years because she was seven feet tall.

They would go on doing it now for entirely different reasons, and it was going to take her about a month to notice, and rather longer than that to decide whether she minded.